Saturday, December 30, 2023
Poush 14, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Thinllaga Tritiya

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 14 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: RSS

A herd of elephants being treated with their most preferred fodder at the 17th elephant and tourism festival in Sauraha of Chitwan district on Friday. A total of 65 elephants participated in the unique feasting.

Tree clearance endorsed for Fast Track road

Advisors appointed at Gorkhapatra Corporation

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 29

The government has allowed to cutting of 4,345 trees standing in the forest areas along the Kathmandu-Tarai/Madhes Fast Track (Expressway) Project in the Bara and Makwanpur districts.

CABINET DECISIONS

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held on December 28 allowed to use 40.19 hectares of the national forest areas of the two districts to give momentum to the Fast Track project.

Speaking at a press conference organised to make the Cabinet decisions public on Friday, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma said that the Cabinet meeting held on December 21 allowed the use of 10.13 hectares of national forest area in Rasuwa district by cutting 1,214 trees of the forest area to begin the tower construction of the transmission line for Sanjen Hydropower Electricity Project.

The government has appointed Ram Krishna Adhikari of Suryagadhi Rural Municipality-2 of Nuwakot district as advisor to the Gorkhapatra Corporation's Management, Printing and Financial sections.

Similarly, Sushila Chaudhary of Ghorahi Sub-Metropolitan City-17 of Dang has been appointed as a legal advisor to Gorkhapatra Corporation for two years.

Upon the proposal tabled by the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology, the Cabinet meeting held on December 21 decided to appoint Adhikari and Chaudhary to their respective posts under Section 14 (1) of the Gorkhapatra Corporation Act-1963.

Also, the government has given managerial authority for the management of the Annapurna Conservation Area and Manaslu Conservation Area to the National Trust for Nature Conservation (NTNC).

The Cabinet meeting has also promoted two Brigadier Generals of the Nepali Army to the post of Major General and nine Colonels to the post of Brigadier General.

Likewise, the government has annulled six Nepali citizenship certificates issued by the Siraha District Office.

The government has appointed Srijana Malla Rana of Kathmandu-15 and Lok Bhakta Shumsher Rana as members of the Dreams of Garden Development Board.

ECONOMY IS IMPROVING: PM

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Charikot, Dec. 29

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the country's economy is improving.

Inaugurating the Brihat Dolakha Fair here on Friday, Prime Minister Prachanda said that, even though the economy was in crisis when he took office, it was gradually improving now.

Pledging to change his style of working now that he has completed one year as the Prime Minister, he said that he would emphasise the development of the country.

Highlighting that both remittance and tourist numbers had increased, he asked businesses not to worry and said that he had prioritised economic recovery by holding multiple rounds of discussions with the private sector.

Similarly, the Prime Minister stressed that he would focus on developing tourism in Dolakha and expressed his support for the sports stadium being constructed in the district. He also promised to assist in the construction of a film city here. Furthermore, he expressed belief that the Dolakha Fair would help revive the economy of the district and the country.

He felt that Dolakha would be successful in formulating a sustainable model of economic development based on local capacity and said that the Upper Tamakoshi project had demonstrated that large projects could be built with domestic investment. Prime Minister Prachanda promised the government would formulate the policies, provide technical assistance and manage resources to support economic prosperity.

'Solution to electricity tariff arrears will be found'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 29:



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has expressed his commitment to find a proper solution to the dedicated feeder and trunk lines tariff arrears disputes after discussing with the concerned agencies. During a discussion with the dedicated and trunk line affected industrialists on Friday, Prime Minister Prachanda said that he was in favour of finding a solution to the dedicated and trunk line disputes in a positive manner, without offending anyone.

The delegation led by President of Confederation of Nepalese Industries Rajesh Kumar Agrawal met the Prime Minister and drew his attention to the issues of dedicated and trunk lines arrears disputes.

According to a press statement issued by the CNI, Prime Minister Prachanda told the industrialists that since this dispute had been going on for a long time, he had a clear understanding that the tariff for used electricity should be paid and the tariff for the unused electricity should not be paid. During the meeting, industrialists requested the PM to resolve the dispute according to the legal system at the earliest.

The Confederation has requested to publicise the details of the TOD meters of the industries which are said to be running their industrial enterprises by consuming electricity from the Authority's dedicated feeders and trunk lines during load-shedding.

The CNI also urged the Prime Minister to immediately connect the electricity of those industries whose lines have been cut citing that there were arrears without actual base and proof or non-payment of arrears.

Earlier, the NEA had cut the lines of nine of 61 industries which have not paid the huge electricity arrears.According to the Authority, 61 industries have to pay Rs. 22.24 billion in arrears.

In that meeting, President of the Confederation Agrawal said that the industrialists were paying the tariff according to the regular bills issued by the Authority and the industries were also taking incentives for timely payment of bills as per the provision of NEA.

The amount which is said to be not paid by the industries was only premium or special charges for dedicated feeder or trunk line. Agrawal said that if the NEA proved that industries had been availed that special facilities, then all the industries would pay the arrears.

"This issue has been disputed for a long time, some industries have gone to the court, but it has not yet been resolved. In such a situation, cutting the power of the manufacturing and export-oriented industries operating at low capacity will have a negative impact on the overall economy and will send a negative message," Agrawal said.

Former president of Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry Pashupati Murarka, senior vice president of FNCCI Anjan Shrestha, vice president of CNI Amit More and other affected industrialists participated in the discussion.

NC meet continues

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 29

In its Central Working Committee (CWC) meeting, the Nepali Congress leaders discussed the performances of the government, current political developments, the Mahasamiti meeting and organisational issues for the second consecutive day on Friday.

In the meeting, Foreign Affair Minister NP Saud presented his ministry's 49-point performance during one year claiming that relations of the country with friendly countries were strengthened.

"The government is running the foreign policy on the basis of the UN Charter, Panchsheel principle, world peace and international laws," Saud said.

Likewise, Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat, Urban Development Minister Sita Gurung, Youth and Sport Minister Dig Bahadur Limbu, Women, Children and Senior Citizen Minister Surendra Raj Acharya briefed the performance of their respective ministries.

Altogether 32 CWC members, including Gyanendra Bahadur Karki, Uma Regmi, Arjun Prasad Joshi, Ananda Prasad Dhungana, Dr. Chandra Kanta Bhandari, Ajay Kumar Chaursiya, Ishwori Neupane, Kalyan Kumar Gurung, Kiran Yadav, Dr. Gopal Dahit, Yogendra Chaudhary and Kiran Raj Sharma Paudel aired their views in the meeting.

They urged party leadership to pick the candidates for the National Assembly member election as per the party norms.

They urged the leadership to prepare standards of candidate selection for the National Assembly member election.

Member Ram Hari Khatiwada urged the party should not pick candidate on the basis of factions, kinship and donation.

CWC member Ajay Babu Siwakoti also stressed the need for formulating standards to pick the NA election candidates.

He underlined the need for launching a campaign of NC with new generation.

NC publicity department chief Meen Bishwokarma informed that next meeting is scheduled for Saturday at 12.30 pm.

The meeting decided to draw the attention of the government on the incident of Balkumari stating that a vehicle boarded by a minister was set on fire and two persons were killed and others were injured when the police tried take the situation under control.

The party urged the government to investigate the incident and make the facts public.

Two die in Balkumari protest, govt forms probe committee

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 29

At least two persons were killed during a protest of the irritating youth after they were not allowed to take the Employment Permit System (EPS) examination on Friday morning.

One has to pass the EPS exam to go to South Korea as a migrant worker from Nepal. But when a group of youth were unable to take the exam, they took to the street prompting the police to use force.

The Central Police Spokesperson and Deputy Inspector General Kuber Kathayat told The Rising Nepal that Birendra Shah, who was receiving treatment at Patan Hospital, had died.

Likewise, 23-year-old Sujan Raut, who was admitted to Kist Hospital after he was injured, died. Raut had sustained an injury on his chest.

Although the police said that Raut had died of a bullet injury, the hospital said it did not see any bullet injury on Raut's body. Instead, there is a mark which looked like a hitting by a baton on the chest, Chief of Operation of the Kist Hospital, Amish Pathak said.

Pathak said that Raut, who was brought to the hospital at around 12:40, was pronounced dead at 1:17 although the medical team tried to revive his consciousness by giving him CPR. The reason behind his death will be known only after an autopsy, said Pathak.

The EPS office said that the youth who had filled up the examination form for the shipbuilding company would not be able to take the examination for other fields. The youths later went to the court against the decision but failed to fill up the form.

The court ordered to allow them to participate in the examination to be held in the productive and agricultural sectors. However, the EPS office had invited only those who had filed the writ in the court to apply for the exam. When other students could not fill up the forms, they demonstrated. During the demonstration in Balkumari, Lalitpur, police initially fired tear gas to control the demonstration.

After failing to take the Employment Permit System (EPS) exam, the protesting youth also set a government car boarded by the Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport Prakash Jwala on fire.

Meanwhile, the Ministry of

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Nepal makes progress in diplomacy

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 29

The first year of the current government witnessed major progress in foreign affairs and diplomacy including rescuing Nepalis from Israel and Ukraine, repatriation of the mortal remains of Nepali nationals killed in the HAMAS attack in Israel, and various high-level bilateral and multilateral visits and engagements.

Likewise, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) implemented programmes for economic diplomacy, and services to Nepali citizens in foreign countries, implemented multilateral diplomacy, organised and attended meetings of bilateral mechanisms formed with the friendly nations.

Briefing the Central Committee meeting of the Nepali Congress on Friday, Minister for Foreign Affairs, NP Saud, said that Nepal successfully brought back Nepali citizens who were at risk due to the war between Israel and Palestinian rebel group HAMAS, repatriated the bodies of 10 Nepalis killed in the attack while a search is going on to find the missing Nepali student, Bipin Joshi.

Likewise, 31 Nepalis stranded in Sudan due to political crisis there were also rescued with the efforts of the MoFA, and the missions in Cairo, Riyad and Jeddah. India, China and Saudi Arabia also extended their support to Nepal in the rescue operations.

Meanwhile, the Foreign Ministry introduced the pre-enrollment form for passports allowing the service seekers to fix their appointment a month before. It also increased the quota for the forms for passports to district and area administration offices. "We have a stock of passports that will meet the demands for the next two years while the tender process has been initiated to procure additional passports," said FM Saud.

Likewise, the Department of Consular Services has started to approve the character certificate online which has contributed to the decreased time and money of the people and crowd at the office.

Nepal organised a high-level investment summit in London on the occasion of the centenary of the Friendship Treaty 2023 signed between Nepal and the United Kingdom. The summit was successful in drawing the investors' attention to renewable energy, information technology and education.

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One Year of Government

The MoFA also organised various programmes related to economic diplomacy in and out of the country and mobilised Nepali missions abroad to promote Nepal's trade, tourism and investment. The Rasuwagadhi-Kerung border between Nepal and China was opened within a couple of days of FM Saud's appointment to the post. Likewise, the Hilsa-Purang border is also opened for one-way trade.

The opening of these border points will promote the bilateral trade between Nepal and China, said FM Saud.

In the past one year, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' completed the official visits of neighbouring countries India and China. During his visit to India at the invitation of his Indian counterpart, Narendra Modi, various seven agreements were signed and five projects were inaugurated or initiated.

Likewise, during his visit to China, PM Prachanda participated in the inauguration ceremony of the 19th Asian Games and signed various memorandums of understanding (MoUs) and agreements during the meeting with Chinese Premier Li Qiang.

The MoUs were signed for the Hilsa-Simkot Road Project, Nepal China Power Grid Interconnection, cooperation in education, science and technology, and agriculture, development cooperation between the two countries, green development, and cooperation in the digital

Similarly, FM Saud visited the United States of America at the invitation of the US Secretary of State, Antony Blinken. During the visit, FM Saud also held meetings with the CEO of US International Development Finance Corporation, Scott Nathan, Administrator of the USAID, Samantha Power, CEO of the Millennium Challenge Corporation, Alice Albright, and other high-ranking

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Environment created to achieve 6% economic growth: Dr. Mahat

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 29



FILE PHOTO: TRN

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat

Finance Minister Dr Prakash Sharan Mahat has said an environment has been created to achieve six per cent economic growth rate, as the country's economy has started returning to its form gradually.

Inaugurating the 20th annual general meeting of Bhrikutimandap based Kathmandu Valley Public Library Society today, Minister Mahat mentioned that overall situation of country's economy is satisfactory as arrival of tourists, remittance, share price, revenue and economic activities are increasing.

He clarified that anomalies of budget have been controlled by developing budget allocation system based on guarantee of resources in multi-year projects as well as decrease in interest rate of banks has given a positive sign.

The Finance Minister shared that an improvement was made in budget system by ending the trend of extra expenses than stipulated in the budget Red Book. Society president Dr Narayan Khadka underscored on the need of the State to give priority to library as it is the centre of knowledge and information as well as the glory of the change, civilization and history of the nation.

According to him, the government has cut down on the budget for the Society, there is no land plot for the library building and the Social Welfare Council has been increasing the rent of the library block like that for the commercial shops.

Society leading persons Mahesh Agrawal and Tirtha Raj Onta were felicitated on the occasion.The Library was registered with the Kathmandu District Administration Office on September 25, 2003. More than 30,000 visitors annually come to the library. The number of annual members is 2,400.

The Society started running the library from 2005. The library has received 37,614 books as donation while 4,351 books have been purchased, stated the Society.

Balmeeki Vidyapeeth to give land to Library

On the occasion, Chief of Balmeeki Vidyapeeth , Prof Dr Bhagawat Dhakal proposed that land plot can be allotted to the Society for constructing a building of the Society for jointly running the Library at the Vidyapeeth's premises. He broached the idea of the Vidyapeeth and the Society together operating the Library as the former was facing shortage of budget for constructing its own library block and suggested the latter to seek funds for constructing the library building.

Healthy growth of banking sector required for growth of other sectors

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 29

Vice-Chairman of the National Planning Commission (NPC) Dr. Min Bahadur Shrestha has said that a strong banking industry can contribute to the development and growth of the other business sectors.

Speaking at the third annual general meeting of the Confederation of Banks and Financial Institutions of Nepal (CBFIN) in Kathmandu on Friday, he said, "The government is aware of this fact and is paying attention to the healthy growth of the banking sector."

"So far, about Rs. 6 trillion deposits are in the banking sector, and about Rs. 5 trillion is being invested. That investment could not increase production and employment as expected," said Dr. Shrestha, "If this sector contributes to the increment of production and employment, it will also be the first beneficiary of that development."

According to him, among the various sectors of the country, the banking and financial sector is the sector running with international standards.

Dr. Shrestha said that the production in the country decreased and the ever-increasing imports have aggravated the challenges in the economy. "There is a situation that when we try to resolve the problem in one sector, a problem props up in another sector."

Member of the NPC Dr. Ramesh Chandra Paudel said that unless the manufacturing sector was freed from financial problems, production and productivity would not increase and the youth would not get employment. For that, he said, an environment should be created in which up to 20 per cent of the loan amount could be invested in the manufacturing sector.

He said that the interest rates on loans given to the manufacturing sector should be less than that of the service sector.

President of CBFIN Pawan Kumar Golyan urged the NPC to give priority to the financial sector and the private sector in the 16th Plan that would be implemented for the next five years from the Fiscal Year 2024/25. He said that banks and financial institutions are ready to contribute to fulfilling the quantitative targets taken by the NPC.

He also urged the Commission to take the bank and financial sector together in the upliftment and growth of the industry, energy and service sectors along with the agricultural sector to lead the country on the path of development.

Golyan suggested increasing the capital expenditure to improve the overall economy. The CBFIN suggested that the policy arrangements for using domestic products should be implemented compulsorily, preferential interest rates should be maintained for productive, exporting and employment sectors, innovation, development of self-entrepreneurship and improvement and upgrading of domestic, small and medium entrepreneurs and industries should be prioritised.

Addressing the programme, Rajendra Malla, President of the Nepal Chamber of Commerce, said that the economic indicators have turned negative from all sides and single-digit interest rates should be maintained to keep the economy running.

He said that the economy will not be accelerated as long as there is a double-digit interest rate. "The government's economic policy should match the five-year plan. Without that, the economic sector will not be viable," said Malla.

Likewise, Vice-President of the Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) Amit More said that the rule of law should be established in the country, and the arrears would be paid when evidence was found in the dispute with the Nepal Electricity Authority regarding the payments of the dues for dedicated electricity supplied several years ago.

Test production of 10MW solar power project begins in Jhapa

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Damak, Dec. 29



The testing of commercial solar energy production has been started for the first time in Jhapa. Jhapa Energy Company Limited has started testing a 10 MW solar project since Tuesday evening. Around 17.61 million units of electricity will be generated from the project annually.

Narayan Prasad Pokharel, programme officer of the company, said that the energy produced from the project located in Shivasatakshi Municipality-4 was connected to the Bulochowk substation of the Nepal Electricity Authority before the testing began.

He said that the test production of electricity would continue for 15 days before commercial production begins. The Nepal Electricity Authority will purchase electricity produced by this project according to the agreement.

The agreement for the purchase of power has already been signed between Nepal Electricity Authority and Jhapa Energy. It has been informed that the power purchase agreement has been made with the NEA at the rate of Rs. 7.30 per unit.

According to Jhapa Energy, the agreement for the purchase of electricity was inked on November 28, 2021. The project has been brought into operation with an investment of Rs. 810 million, with 75 per cent of the investment from the Machhapuchchre Bank and Civil Bank and 25 per cent from the people.

To connect the generated solar power to the national transmission line, Jhapa Energy itself has built a 960-meter transmission line, Pokharel said.

The Jhapa people living in various areas, including Kathmandu and abroad have worked collectively on some projects and this project has been successful, said LP Sanwa Limbu, Member of the House of Representatives. Limbu had led the construction of the solar project.

FNCCI ASKS FOR HIGH-LEVEL COMMISSION TO RESOLVE DEDICATED FEEDER

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 29

FNCCI President Chandra Prasad Dhakal urged the government to form a high-level commission to immediately address the dispute surrounding dedicated power feeders and trunk lines provided to the industries.

It may be noted that the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) had recently disconnected dedicated electricity lines (named dedicated feed and trunk lines) of some industries citing unpaid dues.

In the Dolakha Festival's inaugural in Charikot, Dolakha today, President Dhakal said that this dispute would further diminish the morale of the entrepreneurs and would further deteriorate the investment climate in the country.

FNCCI, issuing a press statement here today, Dhakal viewed that formation of a high-level commission would address the current issue once for and all. He also warned the dispute between the Nepal Electricity Authority and entrepreneurs regarding this would create more problems to the country's economy.

Gold price decreases by Rs. 1,300 per tola

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 29

The prices of gold and silver decreased noticeably on Friday. The price of gold fell by Rs. 1,300 per tola in the domestic market on Friday as compared to Thursday's price. According to the Federation of Nepal Gold and Silver Dealers' Association (FENEGOSIDA), the price of gold decreased to Rs. 120,700 per tola (11.664 grams) today compared to Rs. 122,000 on Thursday.

The price of gold decreased today after setting a record of Rs. 122,000 per tola on Thursday in the local market.

Likewise, the price of silver has also decreased by Rs. 35 per tola to Rs. 1,455. The price of gold decreased sharply on Friday in the local market due to a decrease in its price in the international market, said Tej Ratna Shakya, a gold trader and special member of the FENEGOSIDA.

Fluctuations in the international market price have an impact in the domestic bullion market as well, he said. Gold price in the international market has decreased by US$ 27 per ounce to US$ 2,068 today, he said. The price of gold was USD 2,085 per ounce in the international market on Thursday.

BULLION
(Rs. per tola)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 120,700
Worked Gold	: Rs. 120,100
Silver	: Rs. 1,455

NEPSE	:	2,068.90
Total Amount	:	4,290,932,297.6
No. of Share	:	11,658,110

Maui Island waits for tourists to improve the economy

AP
Hawaii, Dec. 29

The restaurant where Katie Austin was a server burned in the wildfire that devastated Hawaii's historic town of Lahaina this summer. Two months later, as travelers began to trickle back to nearby beach resorts, she went to work at a different eatery. But she soon quit, worn down by constant questions from diners: Was she affected by the fire? Did she know anyone who died?

"You're at work for eight hours and every 15 minutes you have a new stranger ask you about the most traumatic day of your life," Austin said. "It was soul-sucking." Hawaii's governor and mayor invited tourists back to the west side of Maui months after the Aug. 8 fire killed at least 100 people and destroyed more than 2,000 buildings. They wanted the economic boost tourists would bring, particularly heading into the year-end holidays.

But some residents are struggling with the return of an industry requiring workers to be attentive and hospitable even though they are trying to care for themselves after losing their loved ones, friends, homes and community. Maui is a large island. Many parts, like the ritzy resorts in Wailea, 30 miles (48 kilometers) south of Lahaina — where the first season of the HBO hit "The White Lotus" was filmed — are eagerly welcoming travelers and their dollars.

Things are more complicated in west Maui. Lahaina is still a mess of charred rubble. Efforts to clean up toxic debris are painstakingly slow. It's off-limits to everyone except residents.

Tensions are peaking over the lack of long-term, affordable housing for wildfire evacuees, many of whom work in tourism. Dozens have been camping out in protest around the clock on a popular tourist beach at Kaanapali, a few miles north of Lahaina. Last week, hundreds marched between two large hotels waving signs reading, "We need housing now!" and "Short-term rentals gotta go!"

Hotels at Kaanapali are still housing about 6,000 fire evacuees unable to find long-term shelter in Maui's tight and expensive housing market. But some have started to bring back tourists, and owners of timeshare condos have returned.

Karnali-Chisapani hydropower project: Estimated cost Rs 1.147 trillion

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 29



A process for the study of the Karnali Chisapani Hydropower Project, the largest hydropower project of South Asia, has been forwarded. As per the current price, the estimated cost of the project is Rs 1.147 trillion.

The Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) forwarded the study process of the 10,800-MW project with its own resources. A high-level team comprising Minister for Energy, Water Resources and irrigation, Shakti Bahadur Basnet, Energy Secretary Sushil Chandra Tiwari, Director General of Department of Irrigation, Churna Bahadur Oli and NEA Executive Director Kulman Ghising carried out onsite visit of the project site as well as the project-affected site on December 25 and 26.

The NEA has forwarded study process of Karnali Chisapani Project in order to complete it within next three years. Locals are very excited after the government forwarded the study process, giving the project special importance.

The talk of construction of this project has enthused the locals in the hope that it will continue the development the construction of the Karnali Chisapani Bridge brought in west Nepal.

Khadga BK, Chairperson of Panchapuri rural municipality, Surkhet, said they would provide meaningful cooperation to make the project successful.

"We are excited to know about the news that such a mega project is being constructed in our area. We are exhilarated. We urge the federal government to move ahead the process by addressing the justified demands of the locals," he added.

The reservoir of the proposed project would be constructed nearly two kilometres above the Karnali Chisapani bridge that connects Bardiya and Kailali districts. The Karnali River would be dammed by constructing a 270 metres tall dam. Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA)'s current study stated that it would be a 'rock fill dam'.

The reservoir would be 167 kilometres long – 100 kilometres on the Karnali river, 45 kilometres on the Bheri river, 16 kilometres on the Seti river, six kilometres on the Thuligad river, according to NEA senior engineer Nasib Man Pradhan who was involved in the study.

The project will affect the settlements and structures located near the river in Bardiya, Kailali, Surkhet, Achham and Doti districts.

As per a study conducted in 1989, the project will affect a total 11,570 hectares area and 54,600 locals. NEA said the affected area would be clearly identified by studying the latest situation.

Minister Gurung emphasises impartial corruption probe



PHOTO: RADHAKRISHNA DUMRE

Minister for Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs, Dhanraj Gurung, speaking at a press conference organised by Nepal Press Union, Syangja, Friday.

RSS
Waling (Syangja), Dec. 29

Minister for Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs, Dhanraj Gurung, pressed for a bold and impartial investigation into cases of corruption.

Speaking at a press conference organised by Nepal Press Union, Syangja on Friday, Minister Gurung called for a stringent investigation into corruption cases, stating that the involvement of influential people in such cases has led to lax investigation.

Expressing his dissatisfaction over the investigation process, Gurung said, "When the investigation into corruption and gold smuggling among others begins, the names of influential people are attached which impedes the investigation in the process."

He said that such a tendency should be ended and the culprits should be brought to justice.

On a different note, Minister Gurung said that the Prime Minister could consider reshuffling the Cabinet in the consensus of the coalition partners. "The reshuffling could also be considered through evaluation of the ministers' performance and at the approval of the party," the Minister said.

He said, "Those who could work in tandem and in the spirit of the PM could be accommodated in his cabinet. Those who cannot deliver well could be sent off.

Construction company leaves six projects in neglected state in Palpa

BY REKHIRAM RANA
Tansen, Dec. 29

A single construction company, Jaya Raktakali Construction Pvt. Ltd. Nuwakot, has held six major projects incomplete in Palpa district.

It left projects under the Road Division Office, Road Infrastructure Development Office and Tansen Municipality unfinished for years.

The offices informed that the construction company had left the projects in a neglected situation for more than a decade.

A project to build a cold storage facility in Baghkhor of Prabhas, Tansen Municipality, has not been completed even 11 years after its construction began. Bharat Acharya, information officer of Tansen Municipality, said that the contractor abandoned the project after completing only 28 per cent of the work. Jaya Raktakali and Himdung and Thokar Pvt. Ltd. had won the contract to build the cold storage.

Similarly, the Chilangdi–Chappani–Ramdi road section, considered as an important road in the northern part of the district, has also been left in bad shape by the same construction company.

Basudev Yadav, head of the Road Infrastructure Development Office, Palpa, informed that the road project was assigned to the company in 2016 at Rs. 83.1 million. The delay in maintaining the road has led to the deterioration and potential collapse of the road section.

Baburam Sapkota, chief of the Road Division Office, informed that the construction company had neglected its four major projects. He said that the projects include road repair and maintenance in various sections of the Siddhartha Highway, the road project of Rampur–Aryabhanjyang road and others.

> The Chilangdi–Chappani–Ramdi road section, considered as an important road in the northern part of the district, has also been left in bad shape by the same construction company.

Meanwhile, Ram Prasad Bhatt, a representative of the Jaya Raktakali Construction Pvt. Ltd. Nuwakot, said that delays were due to non-payment from the Road Division Office.

Dhanusha man returns home after 35 years

BY BIJAY KUMAR SHAH
Dhalkebar, Dec. 29

Ram Hridaya Mandal of Nausaya Bigha in Dhanusadham Municipality-5, Dhanusha, returned home after 35 years on Saturday.

Mandal left for India at the age of 16 to find work to support his family. He said, "I don't remember the exact year I went to India. Back then, while attending a marriage procession I reached my mother's place and from there I left for India with a friend."

According to Mandal, after two years of staying in Assam, India, his father came to take him back, but, he refused to go with his father and after a few months, he lost his mental balance. Later, he worked in Calcutta, New Delhi and other major cities of India. Moving from one city to another, when he reached a city near the Nepal-India border, he regained his memory and returned to Nepal.



PHOTO: BIJAY KUMAR SHAH/TRN

Ram Hridaya Mandal of Nausaya Bigha in Dhanusadham Municipality-5, Dhanusha.

Since Mandal had arrived in the village after such a long time; many were in doubt if he truly was Mandal.

However, he was able to describe past events to the villagers and some elderly locals were able to recognise him from his childhood injuries marks on his body. Jaisi Yadav, 67, a neighbour, claimed that Mandal's face resembled his brother.

Mandal left the village eight months after his marriage, at the time, his wife was two months pregnant. Now, his son Pramod Mandal is working abroad.

Mandal is the eldest son in his family and has three brothers and a sister. His parents died two years ago.

Int'l meet on 'Religion and Science' concludes

BY RADHAKRISHNA DUMRE
Waling, Dec. 29

An International Conference on 'Religion and Science' concluded on the bank of the Kaligandaki River on Thursday.

To produce sage scientists, the conference was jointly organised by the Kaligandaki Jnanbigyan Foundation and the Chaitanya Saswata Sabha of West Bengal, India.

Speakers at the conference concluded that only spirituality could maintain human and moral values.

The Vedas are the world's first scientific texts, they said.

Speaking at the event, Paramacharya of Saswat Sabha and scientific doctor Bhakti Niskam Sant Maharaja of India said, "Veda is the origin of all inventions."

He said that physics does not understand the essence of life, so spiritual science was indispensable to understanding the science of life.

> The Foundation has taken an initiative to build a larger religious centre named Uttar Bahini, as the Kaligandaki flows towards north from south in the area.

At the event, Chaitanya Krishna Prabhu, President of the Kaligandaki Gayanbigyan Foundation, emphasised bringing religions, rituals, cultures and science together.

Working papers in both English and Sanskrit languages were presented at the conference.

Various people from Nepal and India reached Syangja to participate in the religious event.

The Foundation has taken an initiative to build a larger religious centre named Uttar Bahini, as the Kaligandaki flows towards north from south in the area.

Rs. 85 million collected at Pathibhara temple

BY CHANDRA PANDAK
Taplejung, Dec. 29

Cash offerings of nearly Rs. 85 million have been collected at the famous Pathibhara (Mukkumlung) Temple in Taplejung.

Organising a press conference on Thursday, officials of the Pathibhara Area Development Committee informed that Rs. 84,594,336 had been collected in cash offerings till December 16 this fiscal year. Of this amount, Rs. 6,811,110 was collected in the two months between mid-October and mid-December, the committee's Executive Director Prajin Hangbang said.

From the collected offerings, Rs. 1,070,787 had been spent till December 16. According to Hangbang, this amount was spent on employee remuneration, transportation and management of the gathered money, food for security personnel and project monitoring.

"The remaining amount has been deposited in Nepal Bank, Laxmi Sunrise Bank, Sanima Bank, Prabhu Bank and NMB Bank," Hangbang said. The Committee shared that Rs. 68.8 million had been kept in these banks as fixed deposits and they had earned an interest of Rs. 258,440 in the last two months.



PHOTO: CHANDRA PANDAK/TRN

The officials counting the cash offerings at Pathibhara (Mukkumlung) Temple premises in Taplejung.

In addition to the cash offerings, the temple also received 186 Tolas six Lals of gold from devotees.

Similarly, it has 92 kilograms and 650 grams of silver, 6,539 kilograms and 775 grams of copper and 16,368 kilograms of bells made from different metals.

> From the collected offerings, Rs. 1,070,787 had been spent till December 16. According to Hangbang, this amount was spent on employee remuneration, transportation and management of the gathered money, food for security personnel and project monitoring.

The committee informed that it planned to refine the collected gold and silver and sell it soon.

Meanwhile, Rakki Thebe, chairman of the Pathibhara Committee, said that they had begun work to make the donation box more managed, and the offering process more transparent.

He also said that they were focused on making the journey to Pathibhara more convenient for the pilgrims.

102 fugitives held in 13 days of operation by police in Rupandehi

BY LAXMAN POUDEL
Bhairahawa, Dec. 29

More fugitives, who were on the run for many years, have been arrested after the Rupandehi Police Office launched the 'clean sweep operation' campaign for crime control.

The police have been continuously arresting the fugitives of theft, drug abuse and smuggling.

Mobilising separate police teams from the offices from across the district for 24 hours, the police have been arresting a large number of fugitives.

The Rupandehi Police has launched the campaign since December 17. Rupandehi District Police Office Chief and Superintendent of Police Bharat Bahadur B.K. said that in 13 days after the launching of the operation, several stolen motorcycles, people involved in them, absconding defendants, drug traffickers and drug abusers were taken into custody.

The police have arrested 102 absconding defendants and persons sentenced by the court. In total, the arrested persons have been sent to prison for 19 years, 11 months and 17 days, and a fine of Rs. 1.28 million will be collected from the fugitives.

According to SP B.K., 23 stolen motorcycles have been recovered and eight persons involved in them have also been detained by the police.

Four cases related to theft have also been registered in the court against those arrested in cases related to bike theft. The police said that 23 motorcycles of different brands and models including two Royal Enfield, one Bajaj Pulsar 150 cc, six Hero Splendor bikes, three Bajaj Pulsar 220 cc and one Yamaha FZ were seized.



PHOTO: LAXMAN POUDEL/TRN

Deputy Superintendent of Police Manohar Prasad Bhatta and spokesperson for the DPO holding a press conference in Bhairahawa, Friday.

It has also been found that the stolen bikes were first taken to India and brought to Nepal for use after changing their engine and chassis numbers, SP B.K. said.

He said that although the police were regularly working to control the illegal activities, after the launching of the campaign, more wrongdoers were arrested. Similarly, during the campaign, the police seized two cars with the same engine number and started an investigation.

During the operation, the police recovered 43 grams 220 milligrams of brown sugar, six ampoules of Diazepam, 68 ampoules of Phenergan, eight ampoules of Talgesic, 59 ampoules of Serizac, 60 ampoules of IPPL, and 16 capsules of proxy spas.

The police also arrested nine persons involved in drug use and transportation.

Deputy Superintendent of Police Manohar Prasad Bhatta and spokesperson for the DPO said that seven drug cases were registered in the district court.

"Police investigation has shown that in some cases, due to friends' incitement and family's negligence, the youth are involved in illegal activities such as drug trafficking, use and theft", SP B.K. said.

"For this, it seems that families should pay attention to prevent their children's activities from going down the wrong path," SP B.K said.

NEWS BRIEF

Wild tusker kills man in Jhapa

Birtmaod: A man was killed by a wild elephant in Shivasatakshi Municipality-11 in Jhapa.

The deceased was identified as Megh Raj Rai, 46, of the same municipality. The incident happened early in the morning on Friday when Rai was sleeping at his home. He died on the spot, said police. Other family members of the house escaped unhurt, said police.

The food crops of Rai's home were eaten by the wild tusker. The body was taken to a hospital for a postmortem report.

Man dies of alcohol over consumption

Dhalkewar: A man died after consuming excessive alcohol in Dhalkewar of Dhanusha district. Police said that the deceased was identified as 40-year-old Bhupal Bahadur Magar.

The body of Magar was found near the roadside of Durga temple in Dhalkewar. According to the Police Inspector of the Area Police Office, Dhalkewar, Raj Kishwor Sah, a preliminary investigation showed that he died after consuming excessive alcohol. The body has been taken to the Provincial Hospital for an autopsy, said police.

TRN

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

From a small seed a mighty trunk may grow.
-- Aeschylus

Nurturing Vital Links Of Political Stability

Dev Raj Dahal



Securing political stability, good governance and justice delivery are the watchwords of Nepali Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda. Political stability is a condition characterised by the smooth functioning of civic and political institutions and the government and avoiding any atrophy for a relatively long period of time. Its primary precondition is the creation of a constitutional culture whereby roles and responsibilities of all actors — state, market, civil society, people in general and international community as external stakeholders — is well demarcated and they faultlessly consort policies and action for the collective attainment of public good to be shared by all Nepalis regardless of condition and cost.

Neutrality of state institutions from partisan prejudice and their impartial act fulfil the constitutional rights of Nepalis, enabling them to use freedom of action and perform duties to others. Now they are demanding the constitutional behaviour of all so that varied interests of societal sub-systems are optimised and vices of spoilers, free-riders, predators and thieves of state who oppose stability are barred or penalised. It helps reconcile individual liberty with the public good. A lively associational life of Nepalis is vital to put a curb on unregulated opportunism of authorities and orient them to institutional culture of dharma. Value consensus of all political parties in the constitution can offer a hope of stability rather than an elite bargain for power equation which has so far only lingered in transitional politics.

Democratic choice

It did not ease either social transformation or democratic choice for the people. The electoral choice has incubated only a style of hopeless paternalism. Political stability has wider effects than the stability of coalition government. The credibility of the political regime can be a source of political stability if Nepali leaders shoulder the responsibility to bridge the gap between their promises and actual performance. Instability occurs when each political party seeks to maximise its gain without considering its competitor and general mass. This spectacle robs them of the virtue of democratic leadership to alleviate the poor's burden of existence and incurs a huge price to be paid by the nation and people.

It scares both native and foreign investors -- the locomotives of economic transformation.

Conquering the drag on economic resilience is Nepal's critical policy challenge for leaders who are worried with the roiling debate on good governance by abolishing crime, corruption, capital flight and abuse of human rights. The struggle for social justice inscribed in constitution remains an unfinished project. Nepal can achieve political stability if the edifice of its democracy set up on ecological, social, gender and intergenerational justice and reciprocity is buttressed up and the polity creates more winners than losers of the political game. Ironically, the nation presents a shifting site of political elites and recurrent agitations against the establishment as a way to change the regime and constitution, not evolving a culture of peaceful compromise of legitimate interests in the golden mean thus throttling the hope of political stability.

The elongated transitional politics, irresolution of conflict residues and use of instability as a bargaining tool for power feed political instability. In no way it can construct a rational political order trusted by all major groups of the nation. The absence of social learning will let the untreated causes of conflicts jerk all-inclusive reconciliation and perturb the fabric of political stability. Political stability can occur in Nepal if the scale of engagement of people balances the ability of political parties and civic institutions to absorb them, even the newly enfranchised population. The tendency of educated Nepalis to participate in politics outside institutional frame of parties such as civil society, media, professional bodies and social activism indicates skewed party institutionalisation, poor political socialisation, lack of deliberative and feedback culture, arbitrary reading of party statutes, weakness in the management of factions and personalized nature of top leadership.

When party institutions become weak marked by off beam, pusillanimous or egotistic leaders, democracy turns vulnerable to the risk of radicalism, populism, identity politics and post-modern turmoil where inflated demands are articulated with no intention to satisfy. Likewise, family-based politics is corrosive to democratic opportunity for ordinary people and their social mobility. It turns them into non-stakeholders of democratic process. In this sense, political stability requires sustained acculturation of leaders and people to democratic norms offering educational opportunities to level up the playing field. In a highly polarised zero-sum politics of Nepal in which both the government and the opposition are constituted by the establishment, popular voices are articulated by the anti-establishment current, social movement forces, even media and small political parties.

The establishment composed of Nepali Congress, CPN-UML and Maoist-Centre for sharing the state power has opened sharp contradictions within them. The rival side in each faction of the party feels alienated by the use of the incumbent's clout against it and delinking objective laws from subjective political preferences. The anti-incumbent forces are planning a series of protests thus turning the mood of Nepali politics combustible. Ordinary Nepalis, let down by undelivered promises, are adding vigour to this mood. In a diverse society like Nepal with inbuilt social checks, leaders should avoid being seen as provocateur for fear of exposure which might cut their legitimacy. Political stability demands institutional and policy robustness and response so that people feel that government acts in an impersonal manner and they are not subordinated to might against their rights.

> When party institutions become weak marked by off beam, pusillanimous or egotistic leaders, democracy turns vulnerable to the risk of radicalism, populism, identity politics and post-modern turmoil.

There is no substitute for Nepalis with good intentions to serve as a guard of political power. Popular sovereignty inherent in them demands to play the role of active citizenship. The long-term structural factors behind Nepal's political instability, economic inertia and social rant and rave are unlikely to encourage positive change with already high unemployment, poverty, labour migration, drain of capital, brain and businessmen, shrinking working population within the nation and productivity decline in both agriculture and industry thus leaving Nepal in the international backwater.

A judicious balance in inputs and outputs can be an indicator of political stability as people find their concerns satisfied and thus build trust in the polity. This, however, requires a green, participatory, productive and decentralised economy, not the consumerist and revenue-based one which only swells food scarcity, unemployment, trade imbalance, debt and dependence thus exhausting the foundation of the nation. Excessive external dependence has already clutched the policy prerogative of the Nepali parliament and political parties. The universal access of Nepalis to the public good can spawn optimal equality and ability to compete in the circulation of wealth and political power and hence eases adequate social mobility.

The constitution has a grand objective to vault the ambition of Nepalis but the kleptocratic networks both inside and outside the polity have drained critical resources and confiscated the capacity of Nepali stage to spur distributive justice. This has infantalised Nepali democracy, bureaucratised its operation and demonstrated the inability of the political class to consciously reflect on the national human condition. As a result, personal passion has dominated the search for public good, inverting democratic politics and sapping the vital links of political stability.

Political stability in Nepal is achieved by strengthening the vital links of Nepali state to society, assertion of national will against internal and external rivals and fulfilling various functions -- taxation, national conscription, immigration control, monopoly on power and punishment, loyalty of people, international recognition and national determination of politics, laws and public policies. Its capacity in keeping its autonomy from special interest groups, entrenchment in society and an ability to create public order -- can abolish the crisis of governability. Capacity building of Nepali state demands establishing a robust legal framework and transparency affirmed by the public's right to information.

The stabilisation of state authority presupposes the unified application of law in the entire society through the mobilisation of its centripetal forces and restoring democratic equilibrium between the establishment and varied oppositions. It outlaws the deadly agents of Nepali polity which converts public interests into private benefits and pushes political stability on the edge of an abyss. This means political stability entails the socialisation of subsidiary groups and political parties as per the rules of constitution and leaders are capable of overcoming both performance and rationality deficits.

Procedural fairness

Restoring political stability in Nepal hinges on keeping procedural fairness of public institutions, their autonomy, integrity and consistency in service orientation so that it can retain politics in the middle-of- the-road to balance the cherished culture and the glitter of modernity. This is possible when it is capable of preventing political parties from capturing the polity for personal and clientele interests. Obviously, a national integrity system rooted in power balance and checks improves the likelihood of stability by enhancing resource collection, allocation, investment and regeneration. It sets the coherence of public admin and politics, admin of justice independent of partisan, pecuniary and personal bias, formation of a virtuous circle of hard institutions of the state affirming loyalty and duty to it and the resilience of soft spiritual, social and cultural capital of Nepali society.

Nothing becomes resonant and resourceful unless it relates to historical roots of Nepalis' tolerance of diversity, dealing with the transition from violence to civil peace and even eliminating future sources of violence. Constitutional state represents the general interest of society, an equal concern of all citizens. As a distributive regime it improves the indicators of progress. By bridging the gap between the winners and losers of the election, government and opposition and haves and have-nots it helps to create a virtuous circle between the state, economy and citizenship in the national space and becomes a bedrock of stout political stability.

(Former Reader at the Department of Political Science, TU, Dahal writes on political and social issues.)

Protection From Winter Pollution

AASHISH MISHRA

Winter is a good season for many reasons – it is easier to sleep, kids get a month or more off from school, it becomes acceptable to lie in bed all day and some fortunate among us get to enjoy snowfall. But one thing that prevents winter from being great is the pollution it brings.

The colder months often see an increase in air pollution, due to factors like the burning of wood or coal for warmth, denser and more stagnant air, and smog. Vehicle emissions and industrial activities also contribute to making our air unhealthy (they are a problem year-round, but their effects are exacerbated in the winter due to a phenomenon known as temperature inversion, where a layer of warm air traps cooler air near the ground and prevents pollutants from dispersing). All these can make us extremely sick and give us serious respiratory ailments. That is why it is crucial to protect ourselves and those around us, especially children, senior citizens and those with pre-existing health problems, from this winter pollution.

Given that we spend a significant portion of our time indoors during winter, it is important for us to keep the air inside our homes and workspaces clean. This can be done by using commercial air purifiers, preferably with high-efficiency particulate air (HEPA) filters, to remove airborne impurities. Admittedly, they can be rather expensive so, if purchasing one is not an option, we can simply keep our windows open. It sounds unappealing during the cold but open windows allow for the circulation of air which, in turn, helps push indoor pollutants out.

The ventilation thing also applies to vehicles. When driving during winter, we should ensure that our vehicle's ventilation system is in proper working order and is able to circulate the air inside. We ought to regularly replace cabin air filters to maintain optimal air quality inside our cars. We must pay great attention to keeping the air we breathe when in confined spaces healthy.

Another thing we can do to keep our air clean is to opt for cleaner heating appliances. When possible, we should choose electric heating systems rather than coal or briquette to heat our rooms. When burning wood, we can seek out improved stoves that release less smoke and particulate matter into the air. We should never burn garbage or plastic for warmth as the fumes they emit can be toxic.

When going out on chilly days, it is a good idea to check air quality indexes to get a sense of how polluted an area is. This is quite easy to do these days as there are numerous websites and apps that provide real-time air quality updates. We can simply type "Air quality <Name of our city>" on Google to see what the atmosphere is like.

If the air quality is too bad, then we should try to reduce our exposure. This means either not going out or using respiratory protection. Regarding the latter point, using respirators equipped with particulate filters is always best. But, since that is not always available, we can go for the next best things which are face masks with ordinary replaceable filters. They do not cost much, can be bought in any medical store and provide some barrier against direct inhalation of harmful particles.

If we are in the habit of exercising outdoors, we should consider changing it during polluted winters. This does not mean to stop exercising but, rather, to exercise in indoor spaces like gyms or our homes. If we absolutely must go outside, we should do so when pollution levels are lower. Morning walks or jogs are not advisable because when we engage in physical activity, we tend to breathe faster and take deeper breaths. When the air is polluted, this means we will be inhaling harmful particles and gases. Walks during winter pollution will do more harm than good.

But whether indoors or outdoors, it is paramount that we keep ourselves hydrated during the winter. Hydration helps the body flush out toxins and supports overall health. That is why we should drink plenty of water, even though we may not feel thirsty when it is cold. We need to understand that our body functions best when it is hydrated.

Summing up, winter pollution is a real health hazard. But with awareness and proactive measures, we can keep ourselves and our loved ones safe. By keeping our indoor air clean, monitoring outdoor air quality, using respiratory protection, practising mindful exercise, staying hydrated and choosing cleaner heating options, we will be able to navigate the winter season without succumbing to the bad air it brings.

The Dangers Of Media Sensationalism

Anupam Bhattarai



Media trials have been increasingly prevalent in Nepal in recent years, impacting public opinion and court cases and sometimes implicating individuals. Sensationalism and speculative reporting are common features of media trials, which can have a significant impact on the legal system. There are serious worries about this phenomenon's effects on the justice system's fairness, which are frequently fuelled by sensationalism and the desire for breaking news. There has been a noticeable increase in high-profile cases in Nepal where public opinion has been significantly shaped by media trials.

Although the media is an essential watchdog, there are worries about how this may affect just legal proceedings due to the hazy boundaries between fact-finding and public opinion advocacy. Sensationalising court proceedings in the public eye, or media trials, have become a divisive topic on a global scale. Concerns regarding possible effects on the incrimination process have been raised in Nepal due to the interaction between the legal system and the media. People are frequently implicated in media trials before they even get a chance to appear in court.

Sensational storylines

The media's tendency to sensationalise situations can breed prejudice, skewing public opinion and thus endangering the accused's right to a fair trial. The ethical bounds of journalism are called into question by this occurrence, as are the wider ramifications for the legal system. Media trials have the power to influence public opinion before a court renders a decision since they are marked by extensive coverage and discussion on legal matters by news outlets. This impact may unintentionally result in the incrimination of parties to legal procedures.

The way that media coverage and the legal system interact has generated discussion over the moral bounds of journalism and how it affects the rule of law. The possibility of skewed reporting, in which media outlets favour sensational storylines over impartial journalism, is one of the main obstacles. This prejudice may contribute to the emergence of a biased environment, which could hinder the ability of defendants to get a fair trial. The public's perception of an individual's guilt may arise even prior to the conclusion of judicial proceedings, so undermining the premise of innocent until proven guilty.

In addition, law enforcement officials may be compelled to rush investigations or make decisions based on public opinion rather than a careful review of the evidence due to the pressure put on them by media trials. This may result in hasty decisions and, occasionally, the false incrimination of innocent people. The ramifications of media trials that result in incrimination extend beyond the realm of law. Premature public judgments can lead to psychological discomfort, reputational harm, and social stigmatisation. The impact of media trials on the lives of people involved cannot be overstated in a society where the presumption of innocence is a fundamental component of justice.

> The media's tendency to sensationalise situations can breed prejudice, skewing public opinion and thus endangering the accused's right to a fair trial.

Beyond specific cases, media trials have a significant effect on incrimination. It may cause individuals to lose faith in the impartiality and fairness of court processes, which could undermine public confidence in the judicial system. The deterioration of trust has the potential to significantly impact the stability of the legal system and the rule of law. Addressing this issue calls for a multifaceted strategy. It is imperative that media controls be strengthened in order to stop the spread of unfounded viewpoints and unverified facts.

In conclusion, the increase in media trials that result in incrimination in Nepal highlights the urgent need for a careful analysis of the interaction between the media and the legal system. In the search for truth and justice, maintaining the values of impartiality, fairness, and the rule of law requires finding the correct balance. The connection in Nepal between media trials and incrimination highlights the necessity of a thorough reassessment of the moral and legal frameworks controlling media coverage of court cases.

Responsible reporting

Finding the ideal balance will uphold due process and fairness in society while safeguarding individual rights and boosting public confidence in the legal system. The fairness of legal proceedings in Nepal may be jeopardised by media trials, which could have an impact on case outcomes and the lives of individuals involved. To guarantee that justice is administered impartially and free from undue influence, it is imperative to strike a balance between the media's watchdog function and responsible reporting. As Nepal struggles with this complicated matter, everyone must work together to protect the rule of law and justice.

(The author is an advocate. @attanupam)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

December 30, 1973

Her Majesty Distributes Sweets

Surkhet, Dec. 29: On the auspicious birthday of His Majesty King Birendra, Her Majesty Queen Aishwarya distributed sweets to the children at the local Bal Mandir this morning, reports RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Enact Law To Utilise Forest Resources



This is in reference to the news report titled "*Lack of regulation hinders utilisation of forest resources*" published in this daily on Dec. 29.

Nepal is one of the very few countries in the world that has set an example of not only in forest conservation but also in increasing forest cover, which at present stands at around 44 per cent and counting.

Nepalis have put great efforts towards conserving and promoting forests right from the community level, and it has so far worked well.

At a time when rampant deforestation around the world has sounded alarm bells, our case can provide a textbook example for the world to tread in our footsteps.

As well as contributing in tackling climate crisis, they are rich in critical resources like medicinal herbs and biodiversity.

Given that our forests are rich in resources, we should be able to harness them to our advantage. The government must step in to enact laws to make this happen.

Kapil Basyal
Texas, USA

TAILPIECE

It seems a farm boy accidentally overturned his wagon-load of corn. The farmer who lived nearby heard the noise. "Hey Wilmer!" the farmer yelled. "Forget your troubles. Come in and have a bite with us. Then I'll help you get the wagon up."

"That's mighty nice of you," Wilmer answered. "But I don't think Pa would like me to."

"Aw, come on." the farmer insisted.

"Well okay," the boy finally agreed, and added, "But Pa won't like it."

After a hearty dinner, Wilmer thanked his host. "I feel a lot better now, but I know Pa is going to be real upset."

"Don't be foolish!" the neighbour said with a smile. "By the way, where is your Pa?"

Wilmer replied, "Under the wagon."

Displaced Palestinians flood town of Rafah

AP
Gaza Strip, Dec. 29

Tens of thousands of displaced Palestinians have streamed into the overwhelmed town of Rafah in the southernmost end of Gaza in recent days, according to the United Nations, as Israeli forces on Friday continued to blast through dense areas in the center of the strip, killing dozens of people.

Israel's unprecedented air and ground offensive against Hamas has displaced some 85% of the Gaza Strip's 2.3 million residents, sending swells of people seeking shelter in Israeli-designated safe areas that the military has nevertheless also bombed. That has left Palestinians with a harrowing sense that nowhere is safe in the tiny enclave.

Israel's widening campaign, which has already flattened much of northern Gaza, is now focused on built-up areas in central Gaza, where Israeli warplanes and artillery pounded the urban refugee camps of Bureij, Nuseirat and Maghazi, leveling buildings, residents said.

But fighting is raging across many areas of Gaza. It has not abated in the north, where Hamas is still battling Israeli troops with tough resistance. And the second-largest city of Khan Younis in the south, where Israel believes Hamas' leaders are hiding, is also a smoldering battleground.

The war has already killed over 21,300 Palestinians and sparked a humanitarian crisis that has left a quarter of Gaza's population starving.

Israel has vowed to dismantle Hamas and bring back more than 100 hostages still held by the militants after their Oct. 7 attack on southern Israel. The assault killed some 1,200 people, mostly civilians.

Israeli officials have brushed off international calls for a cease-fire, saying it would amount to a victory for Hamas.

The U.N. said late Thursday that around 100,000 people have arrived in Rafah, along the border with Egypt, in recent days. The influx crams even more people into one of Gaza's most densely populated areas.

Israel has told residents of central Gaza to evacuate and head toward Rafah and the central city of Deir al-Balah. But even as the displaced have poured in, Rafah has not been spared from Israeli attacks.

A strike Thursday evening destroyed a residential building, killing at least 23 people, according to the media office of the nearby Al-Kuwaiti Hospital.

At the hospital, residents rushed in a baby whose face was flecked with dust and who wailed as doctors tore open its Mickey Mouse onesie to check for injuries. Shorouq Abu Oun fled the fighting in northern Gaza a month ago and sheltered at her sister's house, which is located near Thursday's strike

The displaced arrived in Rafah in trucks, carts and many on foot. Those who haven't found space in the already overwhelmed shelters have built tents on the roadsides, especially near hospitals.

Residents said Friday many houses were hit overnight across Nuseirat and Maghazi. The registration office at the al-Aqsa Martyrs hospital in Gaza's central city of Deir al-Balah said it received the bodies of 40 people, including 28 women, who were killed in Israeli strikes in central Gaza.

At least a dozen people killed as Russia strikes Ukrainian cities

AFP
Russia, Dec. 29

Russia launched a wave of missile strikes on Friday across Kyiv and other Ukrainian cities, killing at least a dozen people and wounding over 70, officials said. AFP reporters in Kyiv heard several powerful explosions in the early hours of Friday and saw thick black smoke billowing from a warehouse.

"We haven't seen so much red on our monitors for a long time," said Yuriy Ignat, a spokesman for Ukraine's air force, explaining that Russian forces had first launched a wave of suicide drones followed by missiles.

"There are people killed by Russian missiles today that were launched at civilian facilities, civilian buildings," presidential aide Andriy Yermak said.

"We are doing everything to strengthen our air shield. But the world needs to see that we need more support and strength to stop this terror," he said on Telegram. Two people were confirmed dead in the capital Kyiv, with more people thought to be trapped under rubble at a warehouse damaged by falling debris, Mayor Vitali Klitschko said on Telegram messenger.

He also said the capital's air defences were working intensively.

A metro station whose platforms were being used as an air raid shelter was damaged, he said.

Sergiy Popko, head of Kyiv's military administration, said a warehouse with an area of around 3,000 square metres (32,300 square feet) was burning in the northern Podil district.

"There are many wounded, the number is being clarified," he said.



PHOTO: AP

In this photo provided by the Ukrainian Emergency Service, firefighters work on a site of a building damaged after a Russian attack in Kyiv, Ukraine, on December 29, 2023.

In other districts of the city, an uninhabited multistorey block of flats also caught fire and a private house was damaged, Popko said.

In the central Shevchenko district, a residential building was damaged and there was also a fire in a warehouse with six believed to be injured, Popko said. Klitschko wrote on social media that there appeared to be three people still under rubble of the warehouse while three others had been rescued.

The overnight attacks came days after Ukraine struck a Russian warship in the occupied Crimean port of Feodosia in a major setback for the Russian navy.

Drones and missiles struck at least five other Ukrainian cities on Friday, including Kharkiv in the northeast, Lviv in the west, Dnipro in the east and Odesa in the south, the cities' mayors and police said.

"So far we have counted 22 strikes in different districts of Kharkiv," the mayor, Igor Terekhov, said on television.

"There are currently seven injured in hospital. Unfortunately one person has died."

Trump blocked from primary ballot in two states

AP
Denver, Dec. 29



PHOTO: AP

Former President Donald Trump speaks during a rally Sunday, Dec. 17, 2023, in Reno, Nev. The Colorado Supreme Court on Tuesday, Dec. 19.

First, Colorado's Supreme Court ruled that former President Donald Trump wasn't eligible to run for his old job in that state. Then, Maine's Democratic secretary of state ruled the same for her state. Who's next?

Both decisions are historic. The Colorado court was the first court to apply to a presidential candidate a rarely used constitutional ban against those who "engaged in insurrection." Maine's secretary of state was the first top election official to unilaterally strike a presidential candidate from the ballot under that provision.

But both decisions are on hold while the legal process plays out.

That means that Trump remains on the ballot in Colorado and Maine and that his political fate is now in the hands of the U.S. Supreme Court. The Maine ruling will likely never take effect on its own. Its central impact is increasing pressure on the nation's highest court to say clearly: Can Trump still run for president after the Jan. 6, 2021, attack on the U.S. Capitol?

After the Civil War, the U.S. ratified the 14th Amendment to guarantee rights to former slaves and more. It also included a two-sentence clause called Section 3, designed to keep former Confederates from regaining government power after the war. Congress did remove that disability from most Confederates in 1872, and the provision fell into disuse. But it was rediscovered after Jan. 6.

Trump is already being prosecuted for the attempt to overturn his 2020 loss that culminated with Jan. 6, but Section 3 doesn't require a criminal conviction to take effect. Dozens of lawsuits have been filed to disqualify Trump, claiming he engaged in insurrection on Jan. 6 and is no longer qualified to run for office.

All the suits failed until the Colorado ruling. And dozens of secretaries of state have been asked to remove him from the ballot. All said they didn't have the authority to do so without a court order — until Maine Secretary of State Shenna Bellows' decision.

The Supreme Court has never ruled on Section 3. It's likely to do so in considering appeals of the Colorado decision — the state Republican Party has already appealed, and Trump is expected to file his own shortly. The Maine decision does force the high court's hand, though.

World population up 75 million this year

AP
New York, Dec. 29

The world population grew by 75 million people over the past year and on New Year's Day it will stand at more than 8 billion people, according to figures released by the U.S. Census Bureau on Thursday.

The worldwide growth rate in the past year was just under 1%. At the start of 2024, 4.3 births and two deaths are expected worldwide every second, according to the Census Bureau figures.

The growth rate for the United States in the past year was 0.53%, about half the worldwide figure. The U.S. added 1.7 million people and will have a population on New Year's Day of 335.8 million people.

If the current pace continues through the end of the decade, the 2020s could be the slowest-growing decade in U.S. history, yielding a growth rate of less than 4% over the 10-year-period from 2020 to 2030, said William Frey, a demographer at The Brookings Institution.

The slowest-growing decade currently was in the aftermath of the Great Depression in the 1930s, when the growth rate was 7.3%.

"Of course growth may tick up a bit as we leave the pandemic years. But it would still be difficult to get to 7.3%," Frey said.

> The worldwide growth rate in the past year was just under 1%. At the start of 2024, 4.3 births and two deaths are expected worldwide every second, according to the Census Bureau figures.

At the start of 2024, the United States is expected to experience one birth every nine seconds and one death every 9.5 seconds.

However, immigration will keep the population from dropping. Net international migration is expected to add one person to the U.S. population every 28.3 seconds.

This combination of births, deaths and net international migration will increase the U.S. population by one person every 24.2 seconds.

PRISM

Stuck deer rescued in Colorado

Colorado: Wildlife officials in Colorado came to the rescue of a deer that managed to get its body stuck in the 6-inch gap between the bars of an automatic gate.

Colorado Parks and Wildlife said Steve McClung, assistant wildlife manager for the Durango area, responded to a report of a young doe stuck in a gate near Durango.

McClung was able to give the doe a push to free it from the gate.

"The doe was exhausted from struggling to get through the six-inch gap in the gate's bars," CPW Durango said in a Facebook post. "While it did sustain some wounds, this deer was able to walk away from this incident."

Bonzo dog from 1927 up for auction

A rare stuffed dog made in the likeness of a cartoon character in 1927 is up for auction and is expected to fetch up to $45,000.

EJ's Auction & Appraisal said the Steiff Begging Bonzo Dog, one of only 115 produced, was based on British artist George Studdy's cartoon character, Bonzo.

"They come up for sale now and again, not very often," Neil Redmond, senior appraiser at EJ's, said in a news release. "This is not something you're going to buy and let your dog play with or give it to a child. This is going to be a specialty piece; it really is rare."

The auction house said the dog was purchased by a Phoenix resident at a Michigan flea market nearly 40 years ago.

(AP)

Women's rights and wronged in 2023

AFP
France, Dec. 29

The year saw progress on women's rights in some countries, such as Spain's introduction of menstrual leave, France's bid to enshrine abortion rights in the constitution and the arrival of the #MeToo movement in Taiwan. But there were also setbacks in 2023, from Taliban edicts tightening restrictions on Afghan women to what the UN called a "global epidemic of femicide".

The year 2022 was marked by major convulsions in women's rights across the world, from the US Supreme Court's overturning of Roe v. Wade to the "Woman, life, freedom" chants in Iran, which were followed by a massive government crackdown.

This year saw more gradual developments, from the continuing assaults on and pushback against diminishing abortion rights in the US to the steady disappearance of women from public life in Afghanistan.

Spain becomes first European country to introduce menstrual leave

In February, Spain became the first European country to pass a law creating menstrual leave for women suffering from painful periods. Equality Minister Irene Montero – from the far-left Podemos party, part of the Socialist-led ruling coalition – called it "a historic day for feminist progress".

The law, which passed by 185 votes in favour to 154 against, entitles employees experiencing period pain to time off, with the state social security system – not employers – picking up the tab.

As with paid leave for other health reasons, it requires a doctor's approval. The length of sick leave was not specified in the law. The new legislation also allows minors aged 16 and 17 to have an abortion without parental permission, reversing a requirement introduced by a previous conservative government in 2015.

The effect was instantaneous. Over the weeks that followed, several Taiwanese women broke social taboo to reveal their experiences at work. Female employees of the ruling Democratic Progressive Party kicked off the first major wave by accusing powerful politicians of sexual harassment and assault. The phenomenon spread to cultural and academic circles, with alleged victims accusing celebrities, doctors and professors.



PHOTO: AFP

A demonstrator at a rally marking International Day for the Elimination of Violence against Women in Asuncion, Paraguay on November 25, 2023.

In its June 2022 ruling that overturned Roe v. Wade, the US Supreme Court ended a half-century federal protection of abortion rights and allowed each state to legislate on the issue.

In 14 states, abortion has been outlawed, in some cases without exceptions for rape or incest. On the other hand, 17 states enacted laws or held referendums to protect abortion rights. In other states, access to abortion is not prohibited, but is threatened by laws designed to restrict or prohibit the procedure. This is notably the case in Montana, Wyoming, Indiana and Ohio.

In April, a legal battle over the abortion pill opened a new front in the US battle for reproductive rights when a Texas district court judge invalidated the Food and Drug Administration's (FDA) approval of the abortion pill.

Days later, an appeals court struck down parts of the Texas judge's ruling, but affirmed many restrictions on access to mifepristone, the abortion drug. The Justice Department under the Biden administration as well as the company manufacturing mifepristone sought emergency relief from the Supreme Court, which temporarily halted any changes.

In December, the Supreme Court agreed to hear an appeal by the FDA and mifepristone manufacturer Danco Laboratories. A decision is expected by end-June 2024, making abortion rights a likely campaign issue ahead of the 2024 US presidential election in November.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1066 – Granada massacre: A Muslim mob storms the royal palace in Granada, crucifies Jewish vizier Joseph ibn Naghrela and massacres most of the Jewish population of the city.
1813 – War of 1812: British soldiers burn Buffalo, New York.
1816 – The Treaty of St. Louis between the United States and the united Ottawa, Ojibwa, and Potawatomi Indian tribes is proclaimed.
2006 – Former President of Iraq Saddam Hussein is executed.
2009 – A suicide bomber kills nine people at Forward Operating Base Chapman, a key facility of the Central Intelligence Agency in Afghanistan.
2013 – More than 100 people are killed when anti-government forces attack key buildings in Kinshasa, Democratic Republic of the Congo.



PHOTO: RSS

Workers working in a honey bee farm at Tulasipur Sub-Metropolitan City in Dang district.

UML is a party with vision: Chair Oli

RSS
Chitwan, Dec. 29

CPN (UML) Chair KP Sharma Oli has said the UML has the onus of defending the nation's sovereignty, independence, territorial integrity and nationality, thereby raising high the national prestige.

Addressing a party workers' meeting organised by CPN (UML) Chitwan at Kalika Municipality on Friday, he said the UML had demonstrated that it could work as it was a party with a clear vision.

As he said, the expansion of the Madan Bhandari highway and widening of the East-West highway had been started and the railway extended up to Janakpur by initiating it when the UML was leading the government.

"A separate energy had been transmitted among the people when the UML was in the government. We had made efforts to bring a wave of development," the UML Chair and former Prime Minister said, adding that the party's campaign is for bringing change in Nepal and to make the country prosperous.

He asserted that the campaign is also for making the people happy and the party is ready for a movement for addressing the public's problems.

Party Chair Oli also instructed the party cadres to move ahead with self-confidence. He advised the party leaders and cadres to not discriminate between the new and old faces in the party.

WATER SUPPLIES FROM MELAMCHI BY THIRD WEEK OF JANUARY: MINISTER YADAV

RSS
Sindhupalchowk, Dec. 29

Minister for Water Supplies, Mahendra Ray Yadav, has assured that water supplies from the Melamchi River to Kathmandu will be restored by the third week of January 2024.

The Minister on Friday visited Ambathan to oversee the Melamchi Water Supply Project's source. As he said on the occasion, ongoing efforts to repair the project are progressing well, and the people of the Kathmandu Valley will have access to water in less than a month.

Project's senior divisional engineer Padam Bahadur Kunwar said repair works for the Project was speedy, aiming to restore the water supply chain within the specified timeframe.

The government aims to distribute 170 million litres of water daily to the Kathmandu Valley from the Melamchi River based in Sindhupalchowk district.

Federal government should entrust power to provinces: CM Yadav

RSS
Hetauda, Dec. 29

Chief Minister of Madhes Province, Saroj Kumar Yadav, has said the federal government should entrust powers to each province as soon as possible to make federalism sustainable and strong.

At a programme organised at Hetauda of Makawanpur, Chief Minister Yadav urged the federal government to distribute revenue in provinces and local levels in justifiable manner. He further said a meeting of Chief Ministers of all seven provinces organised at Hetauda of Makawanpur today itself would submit a report along with different suggestion to the federal government.

The Chief Minister laid emphasis that the three-tier government should honestly involve to make the people aware of federalism and republic.

Similarly, Chairperson of Municipal Association of Nepal, Bhim Prasad Dhungana, and Chairperson of National Federation of Rural Municipalities, Laxmi Devi Pandey, said the existing laws should be revised to make people's representatives to perform their responsibilities in local levels as per the sentiments of federalism and constitution.

They mentioned that the federalism should move ahead by distributing budget equally to province and local government without neglecting local levels.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister of Koshi Province, Kedar Karki, said that there was no possibility of holding mid-term election in his province.

At a press meet in Hetauda of Makawanpur district today, CM Karki said that the current all-party government will continue to function in his province and assured of taking forward the public service delivery and developmental endeavors.

Pledging to give completion to the incumbent Koshi Province's government soon in the consensus of political parties in the province, the CM vowed to lead the implementation of the federalism.

He said that his Province was playing a strong role in enforcing the federalism.

On a different note, he accused that federal government and parliamentarians were focusing on matters other than their responsibilities for publicity.

He observed, "Although the federal government ought to endorse the federalism that played an important role in bringing about positive socio-economic transformation in the lives of general public, it failed to do so and thus there was a mob of people who were trying to threaten the current governance system."

He pointed out the need for the provincial government to pile up pressure on the federal government and House of Representatives to take away the rights enshrined by the constitution to the provincial government.

According to him, discussions on the same were underway in Hetauda for the same. When it comes to enforcing federalism, the CM expressed his confidence that the discussion would proceed in a different way given the expansion of the right of various levels of government and will prod the federal government for decentralization of power among the three-tier of government.

An associate of Russian opposition leader Navalny is sentenced

AP
Moscow, Dec. 29

An associate of imprisoned Russian opposition leader Alexei Navalny was sentenced to nine years in prison on Friday, the latest move in a relentless Kremlin crackdown on dissent.

Ksenia Fadeyeva, a regional legislator who headed a local branch of Navalny's organization in the Siberian city of Tomsk, was convicted on charges of organizing an extremist group. Her lawyers said they would appeal the verdict, arguing that Fadeyeva had ended her involvement with Navalny's organization before the authorities labeled it extremist in 2021.

Navalny's spokeswoman, Kira Yarmysh, hailed Fadeyeva as "honest and brave," saying on X that those who fabricated the criminal case against her will eventually face punishment.

Navalny, the most prominent foe of Russian President Vladimir Putin, is serving a 19-year sentence on charges of extremism. Earlier this month, he went missing for several weeks until his lawyers announced Monday that he has been moved from a prison in central Russia to a remote Arctic prison colony known for its harsh conditions.

Navalny has been behind bars in Russia since January 2021, when he returned to Moscow after recuperating in Germany from nerve agent poisoning that he blamed on the Kremlin. Before his arrest, he campaigned against official corruption and organized major anti-Kremlin protests.

A Moscow court outlawed Navalny's Foundation for Fighting Corruption and about 40 regional offices as extremist in June 2021, shutting down his political network and forcing many of his close associates and team members to leave Russia. Those who stayed have faced prosecution.

Fadeyeva's case is the latest in a string of convictions of regional activists linked to Navalny's work.

Lilia Chanysheva, who headed Navalny's headquarters in the central Russian city of Ufa, was sentenced to 7½ years in prison on similar charges in June, and Vadim Ostanin, who previously headed Navalny's office in the southern Siberian city of Barnaul, was handed a 9-year sentence in July on charges of organizing an extremist community.

And in October, authorities detained three lawyers representing Navalny in what his associates described as part of Kremlin efforts to completely isolate him.

Navalny associate Leonid Volkov has said that he prodded Fadeyeva to leave Russia amid the crackdown, but she refused, citing her obligations to voters. She has been in custody since her arrest in November.

SC SCRAPS PUBLIC HOLIDAY ON 'PEOPLE'S WAR DAY'

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec 29:

The Supreme Court has ordered to revoke the government decision to give a public holiday on 'people's war day' which is observed on Fagun 1.

The decision to invalidate this public holiday was prompted by a writ petition filed by advocate Gyanendra Raj Aran, challenging the Council of Ministers' decision to declare Fagun 1 as a public holiday.

The division bench, consisting of Anand Mohan Bhattarai and Mahesh Sharma Poudel, quashed the decision through a certiorari order.

"Peace process and the transitional justice issues have not reached to a conclusion and a relevant bill is under consideration in the House.

Venezuela will hold military

AP
Bogota, Colombia, Dec. 29

President Nicolás Maduro ordered Venezuela's armed forces to conduct defensive exercises in the Eastern Caribbean after the United Kingdom sent a warship toward Guyana's territorial waters as the South American neighbors dispute a large border region.

In a nationally televised address Thursday, Maduro said that 6,000 Venezuelan troops — including air and naval forces — will conduct joint operations off the nation's eastern coast near the border with Guyana.

Maduro described the impending arrival of British ship HMS Trent to Guyana's shores as a threat to his country. He argued the ship's deployment violates a recent agreement between the South American nations.

"We believe in diplomacy, in dialogue and in peace, but no one is going to threaten Venezuela," Maduro said in a room where he was accompanied by a dozen military commanders. "This is an unacceptable threat to any sovereign country in Latin America."

Venezuela and Guyana are currently involved in a border dispute over the Essequibo, a sparsely populated region the size of Florida with vast oil deposits off its shores. The region has been under Guyana's control for decades, but in December, Venezuela relaunched its historical claim to the Essequibo through a referendum in which it asked voters in the country whether the Essequibo should be turned into a Venezuelan state.

As tensions over the region escalated, the leaders of both countries met in the Caribbean island of St. Vincent, and signed an agreement which said they would solve their dispute through nonviolent means.

During the talks, however, Guyana's President Irfaan Ali said his nation reserved its right to work with its partners to ensure the defense of his country.

On Thursday, Guyanese officials described the visit of HMS Trent as a planned activity aimed at improving the nation's defense capabilities and said the ship's visit will continue as scheduled.

"Nothing that we do or have done is threatening Venezuela," Guyana's Vice President Bharrat Jagdeo told reporters in Georgetown, the nation's capital.

HMS Trent is a patrol and rescue ship that was recently used to intercept drug traffickers off the West Coast of Africa. It can accommodate up to 30 sailors and a contingent of 18 marines, and is equipped with 30 mm cannons and a landing pad for helicopters and drones.

The ship had been sent to Barbados in early December to intercept drug traffickers, but its mission was changed on Dec. 24, when it was sent to Guyana. Authorities did not specify when it was expected to arrive off Guyana's shores.

The United Kingdom's Defense Ministry said the ship would be conducting joint operations with Guyana's defense forces.

Iran executes four people for alleged links with Israel's Mossad

AP
Tehran, Iran, Dec. 29

Iran executed on Friday four people and sentenced several others to prison for having alleged links with Israel's Mossad security service, local media reported.

Mizan, the news website affiliated with the country's judiciary, said three men and one woman were executed Friday morning. It identified the men as Vafa Hanareh, Aram Omari, Rahman Parhazo and the woman as Nasim Namazi. The report didn't say how the deaths were carried out, but Iran usually applies hanging.

The four were charged with kidnapping several Iranian security forces to extract intelligence information, Mizan reported. They were also accused of setting fire to cars and apartments of some of Iran's intelligence agents.

The report also said several others — working with the same group — were each sentenced to 10 years in jail, without giving further details.

This came less than a week after an alleged Israeli airstrike killed a high-ranking Iranian general in Syria.

Iran and Israel have long accused each other of spying and waging a shadow war for years.

Two die in...

Home Affairs (MoHA) has formed a committee to investigate the Balkumari incident which resulted in the death of two persons.

The committee was formed under the coordination of the Valley Police Office and Deputy Inspector General Lalmani Acharya. Assistant Chief District Officer of Lalitpur Amardeep Sunuwar and Deputy Director for the Department of National Investigation Basu Sigdel are its members.

Meanwhile, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma, who is also the government spokesperson, expressed her sorrow over the Balkumari incident which led to the death of two individuals.

"The incident is condemnable and the government expresses its sorrow over the incident. The government, especially the concerned body will take necessary steps to investigate the incident," said Minister Sharma while making the Cabinet decisions of December 21 and 28 public on Friday.

Meanwhile, the National Human Rights Commission (HNRC) said its serious attention was drawn to the incident in which the two injured during the agitation at the Balkumari road of Lalitpur died while undergoing treatment.

Nepal makes progress in...

officials, and discussed strengthening the bilateral relations between the two countries and future cooperation.

FM Saud also participated in the coronation ceremony of the King Charles III of the UK, and attended the 6th Indian Ocean Conference.

Likewise, Secretary General of the United Nations, Antonio Guterres, visited Nepal in October-November this year and held meetings with President Ramchandra Paudel, PM Prachanda, FM Saud and discussed Nepal's peace process, climate change and poverty alleviation as well as appreciated Nepal's contribution to the peacekeeping missions.

Indian Foreign Secretary Vinay Mohan Kwatra visited Nepal earlier this year to discuss about enhancing interconnectivity, energy trade, and cooperation in agriculture, health and other areas between the two countries.

Similarly, UK Minister for Defence People, Veterans and Service Families, Dr. Andrew Morrison, UK Minister of State in the Foreign Commonwealth and Development Office, Anne-Marie Trevelyan, US Under Secretary of State for Political Affairs, Victoria Nuland, European Commissioner for International Partnerships, Jutta Urpilainen, USAID's Administrator, Samantha Power, and China, Xizang Autonomous Region's Party Secretary, Wang Junzheng visited Nepal in the past one year.

Meetings of bilateral mechanisms with China, France, the United Kingdom, the European Union, Belgium, South Korea and Japan were held during the past year. The meetings discussed the high-level visits, economic cooperation, trade, investment and tourism promotion, development cooperation, and cooperation in agriculture, climate change mitigation, human rights, education and culture as well as people-to-people relations.

Meanwhile, Nepal participated in the meetings of BIMSTEC and Asia Cooperation Dialogue. The country also raised its voice on the impact of climate change at the 28th Conference of Parties (COP28) of the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change held in Dubai in November.

Meanwhile, Nepal has got the leadership of the Global Coordination Bureau of the group of the Least Developed Countries (LDCs), elected member of the Economic and Social Council of the UN, and a member of the Peace Building Commission of the UN.

More than 40 dead in Liberia after leaking fuel tanker

AP
Monrovia, Liberia, Dec. 29

A leaking fuel tanker exploded earlier this week as people gathered to collect the gasoline, leaving more than 40 dead, authorities in Liberia said Thursday.

The blast on Tuesday also injured at least 83 people in the town of Totota in the central part of the West African country, health officials said.

Many of the dead were buried in a mass grave on Wednesday because their remains were unrecognizable, said health official Dr. Cynthia Blapook in Bong County. Health authorities said an exact death toll was difficult to confirm because of how badly the bodies were burned.

Liberian Vice President Jewel Howard-Taylor attended the mass funeral.

"We never expected to start the new year like this," Howard-Taylor said.

Health officials said the number of injured could rise as they were not certain everyone had been brought in for



care. A doctor at one hospital treating the injured urged the Liberian government to deploy a disaster management team and to have one in each county to respond to emergencies.

Dr. Minnie Sankawolo-Rocks also pleaded with people not to approach fuel tankers in the hope of collecting much-needed gasoline. Similar deadly accidents have occurred elsewhere in Africa.

"Please, I am begging you," she said.

Despite popularity, 'Aila Luwaya' musician laments lack of support

BY AASHISH MISHRA
Kathmandu, Dec. 29



PHOTO: MANOJ MAHARJAN

Still from Aila Luwaya's music video.

Jhā jhā dhāla bhoye chhénya bhoye nayā
Le le tāla changu he khwā swayā
Ailā luwayā
Dhé dhé chula chhan ailā luwayā chanta swawayā
(**Translation:**
In banquet's bliss, a rhapsody unfurls,
Heart exults as your visage swirls.
You poured me the ambrosial liquor, so intoxicating,
I come to see thy elegance, so captivating)

If you have been to a party – any party – in these past two months, chances are you have heard this song.

Although in Nepal Bhasa, this song has become popular with people from all linguistic backgrounds and has accumulated over 4.7 million views on YouTube since its release on October 20.

This has overjoyed the song's creator Roj Man Maharjan, much like the blissful alcohol he has written about.

"'Aila Luwaya' owes its success to the people who have loved it and listened to it," Maharjan, who conceptualised the track, wrote its lyrics and composed the music, told *The Rising Nepal*. "It is amazing to see how it has transcended ethnic boundaries."

Amazing, but perhaps not unexpected. After all, Maharjan, who has a diploma from the Prayag Sangeet Samiti, Uttar Pradesh, India, made an active effort to include elements from various cultures.

Aila Luwaya's language and setting are Newa, but it uses the folk *Kathe* beat common in Nepali-language *Dohori*s. In Maharjan's own words, the song takes *Dohori*s (duet), an exchange of lyrical phrases between various characters, as a reference. The music also starts with the playing of the instrument *Shehanai*.

"I wanted to have a Newa song in a pan-Nepal style," the 27-year-old musician shared, adding that he spent a year researching and developing this number.

Maybe this cross-cultural nature is what made the song such a success. However, success and support are two different things, Maharjan has found out. He still has over Rs. 50,000 he needs to pay for the production of Aila Luwaya. But he has received little help.

"I have received much praise, but commendation does not pay the bills."

"Non-Nepali language songs also do not get many shows and platforms," he said. "There are limited means for musicians to sustain themselves."

Maharjan shared that the ward office offered to give him Rs. 15,000. "But that is not even remotely enough."

"The government spends money on building and rebuilding the same road three/four times a year. Can't they allocate a certain budget for art and music?" he questioned.

The lack of sponsorships for ethnic music has also broken his heart. Businesses do not believe that indigenous songs can get them a large audience, even though Maharjan has a proven track record.

His song 'Salugu Gacha,' which he helped produce as part of the ensemble Kutupukhu Bhajan Khala and which was released last year, has been viewed 6.8 million times to date. On YouTube, there are over two dozen shorts prepared by remixing that video, and the song garnered acclaim from Nepal Bhasa and non-Nepal Bhasa speakers alike.

Kutupukhu Bhajan Khala is a musical group based in Khokana, Lalitpur. Maharjan, who also lives in Khokana, is a *Tabala* (hand drums) teacher in the group. The Khala has been credited in Aila Luwaya too.

Despite Salugu Gacha's success, Maharjan said that he had a hard time getting support for Aila Luwaya. "This may be why indigenous communities do not produce songs in their mother tongues," he wondered. "If we can get [monetary] offers on only Nepali hits then why should we continue making music in our language?" he expressed his frustration.

"People criticise musicians for overlooking their mother languages but rarely pay attention to the conditions that force them to make that decision."

YouTube could have been a potential source of income, but Maharjan initially did not look at it like that. He has only now begun the process of monetising his channel, meaning that despite his videos' popularity, he has not been able to receive any money from the platform.

But support or not, Maharjan is determined to complete what he called his Nepal Bhasa "hat-trick." After Salugu Gacha, which used a centuries-old folk melody, and Aila Luwaya, which was an original composition, Maharjan shared his will to produce a third song, which he hinted could be in his own voice.

And he is optimistic too. "From the feedback and pledges I have received, I have hope that I will get more assistance for the production of this third song than I got for the first two."



Mainali's three literary works launched

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 29

Three works by Thakur Prasad Mainali, the former Vice-Chancellor of the Nepal Academy of Fine Arts and a distinguished senior sculptor, were unveiled amid a programme held in Kathmandu on Thursday.

The releases include Mainali's collection of writings titled 'Kalaka Kura', a poetry collection 'Mero Kamana' and a comprehensive compilation titled 'Thakur Prasad Mainali: Sirjana Ra Bibechana'.

The book-launch ceremony, jointly organised by Nepal Academy of Fine Arts and the Nepali Contemporary Sculptor Group called 'Arambha', saw a few notable people from the art sector.

Academy's Chancellor Naradmani Hartamchhali, Vice Chancellor Lalkaji Lama, Member Secretary Devendra Thumkeli, Head of Sculpture Department Dineshwar Mahato, and Senior Sculptor Thakur Prasad Mainali jointly released the publications.

Chancellor Hartamchhali appreciated Mainali as a living source of knowledge, emphasising the exemplary nature of his personality and artistic endeavours within the context of Nepali art history.

He highlighted the importance of documenting and passing down the experiences of the previous generation, with Mainali being regarded as a living heritage.

Vice-Chancellor Lalkaji Lama highlighted the necessity of bridging the gap between generations to ensure the preservation of the artistic legacy contributed by earlier generations.

Nepathya's 'Pachaasai Barshama' released

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 29



Folk rock band Nepathya released their latest track, 'Pachaasai Barshama' on Friday, accompanied by a compelling video on their official YouTube channel.

The song depicts a contemplative expression of time, capturing the core of the experiences that individuals have experienced throughout the years.

Issuing a press statement on Friday, the band expressed their intent to capture the essence of lived experiences in this composition.

The song, titled 'Pachaasai Barshama Jug Kaha Pugyo Ni, Garhai Bho Imanko Manchhe Bhetina', which translates to 'Where did the time reach in 50 years, hard to find a man of faith'.

The lyrics delve into the societal discord while maintaining a thread of hope, asserting that individuals with integrity still exist. Amrit Gurung, the lead vocalist and frontman of Nepathya, shared the origin of the song, dating back about six years.

He recalled, "When I turned 50, Anil Adhikari from Tanahun shared a song with me. Finding two lines amusing, I expanded on that concept, incorporating bits I had come across elsewhere and weaving in some of my writings. After a few years of refinement, the song took its final form," mentioned in the press release.

The recording, like other Nepathya songs, took place at their studio in Kalikasthan, Nepal, with sound engineer Iman Bikram Shah contributing from a technical standpoint.

The accompanying music video, directed by Nabin Joshi, offers a visual narrative of Nepathya's journey, combined with newspaper cuttings.

Nabin, a prominent figure in Nepal's advertising sector, has collaborated with the band since 2002. He incorporated elements reflecting the evolution of television technology, symbolising the band's journey from box-shaped TVs to the slim screens and mobile phones of today in the video. The band has released this new song while preparations are underway for their 11th album.

According to the policy of releasing one song at a time 'Bhatbhate' from the album was released last year.

Cher asks court to give her conservatorship over her adult son

AP
Los Angeles, Dec. 29



Cher has filed a petition to become a temporary conservator overseeing her son's money, saying the 47-year-old's struggles with mental health issues and addiction have left him unable to manage his assets and potentially put his life in danger.

The Oscar and Grammy winning singer and actor on Wednesday filed the petition in Los Angeles Superior Court that would give her temporary control of the finances of Elijah Blue Allman, her son with musician Gregg Allman.

Cher's petition says that Elijah Allman is entitled to regular payments from a trust fund. But "given his ongoing mental health and substance abuse issues," she is "concerned that any funds distributed to Elijah will be immediately spent on drugs, leaving Elijah with no assets to provide for himself and putting Elijah's life at risk," the petition says.

Reached through his attorney, Elijah Allman said in a phone call with The Associated Press, "I am well, and able, and of sound mind and body."

He declined to say whether he planned to oppose the petition, or give any further comment.

A court-ordered conservatorship is "urgently needed," Cher's filing says. A judge scheduled a January hearing on the issue.

The filing explicitly seeks to keep control of Elijah Allman's finances from his wife, Marieangela King, from whom he filed for divorce in 2021.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Get ready to make it rain, Aries! You've just become an absolute money magnet as Jupiter turns direct in your 2nd House of Wealth, bringing you fabulous opportunities to increase your net worth.

TAURUS: It's all systems go! Bountiful Jupiter is turning direct in your sign, once again encouraging you to put yourself forward and show off where you can.

GEMINI: You have special permission to let your imagination take over. Jupiter, the guardian of good luck, is turning direct in your dreamy 12th house. This is rather like having a fairy godparent watching over you.

CANCER: Everyone is waiting for you to come out and play. Your popularity is through the roof, thanks to Jupiter turning direct in your 11th House of Global Networks.

LEO: There's no such thing as too successful -- not according to you, Leo. You can set your sights as high as you choose with Jupiter finally moving ahead once more after its five-month retrograde in your 10th House.

VIRGO: The world is opening up to you in a whole new way. Expansive Jupiter is waking after spending the last five months retrograding through your 9th House of Quests.

LIBRA: A windfall is always a welcome event. You may have such fortune in store as bountiful Jupiter turns direct in your 8th House of Shared Finances, bringing a burst of luck to money matters that involve others.

SCORPIO: There's never been a better day to partner up. Your closet relationships are coming into focus as lucky Jupiter spins direct once again in your 7th House of Associations.

SAGITTARIUS: You've got a clear road to your best self ahead of you. The planets are working in your favor as Jupiter wakes up in your 6th House of Daily Routine and starts pushing you forward once again.

CAPRICORN: Step forward and take a bow! You've got cosmic permission to put yourself on display as Jupiter turns direct in your 5th House of Enthusiasm.

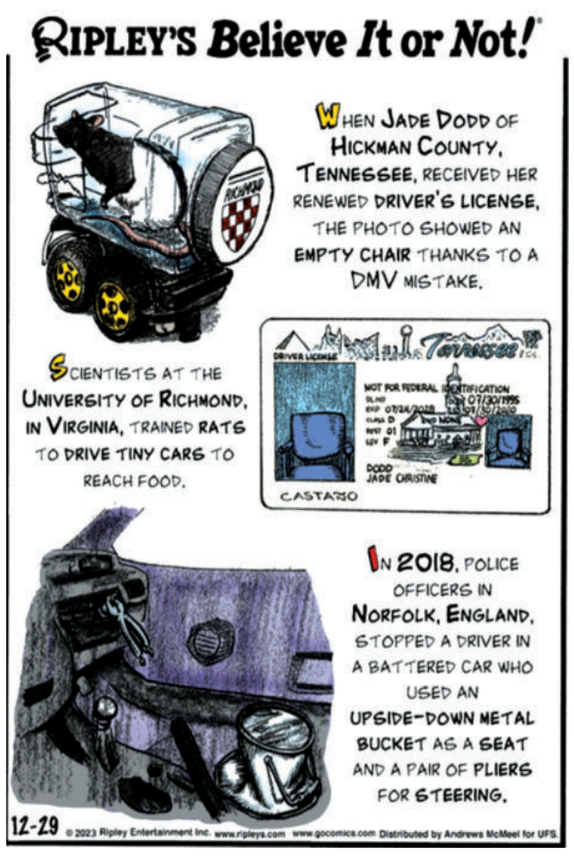
AQUARIUS: Your home is your castle -- or whatever fabulous structure you want it to be. You can make major improvements to your space now that gift-giving Jupiter is waking up from its retrograde phase.

PISCES: There could be something special around every corner. Your neighborhood just became a goldmine of opportunity as Jupiter turns direct in your 3rd House of Local Society.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Cummins the hero as Australia beat Pakistan to win series

AFP
Melbourne, Dec. 29

A fired-up Pat Cummins bagged five wickets and 10 in the match to earn Australia a nail-biting 79-run win in the second Test and clinch the series against a battling Pakistan Friday.

Set 317 for victory, the visitors put up a stellar fight as they chased their first Test triumph in Australia since 1995.

But they were dismissed for 237, with the last five wickets falling for 18 runs.

Cummins was the chief destroyer, taking 5-49 to go with his first innings 5-48 -- only the second 10-wicket haul of his Test career.

Mitchell Starc chipped in with 4-55 as the tail collapsed after Shan Masood (60), Agha Salman (50) and Babar Azam (41) gave them a fighting chance.

It was always going to be a tough task, with the highest-ever successful fourth innings run chase at the Melbourne Cricket Ground the 332-7 England managed in 1928, with no other team getting past 300.

Opener Abdullah Shafique departed for four during a tricky session before lunch, caught by Usman Khawaja in the slips off Starc following a period of intense pressure.

Iman-ul-Haq survived the initial blitz, but was no match after the break for Cummins, who sent down a probing ball that nipped back and trapped him lbw for 12.

Masood was given out lbw by the umpire on 12, but it was overturned on review and he quickly got back in his stride.



He took a nasty ball to the ribs that needed treatment, but was undeterred and raced to a gutsy 50 before Cummins again came to Australia's rescue, enticing an edge to Steve Smith.

There was plenty resting on the shoulders of Azam as the side's premier batter and he looked in good nick.

But after reaching 41, Josh Hazlewood got a ball to jag back and it clattered into his off stump.

Mohammad Rizwan also looked dangerous on his way to 35 before Cummins again worked his magic, with Alex Carey collecting a catch behind the stumps after the ball went off the batsman's glove. Cummins then removed Aamer Jamal and Shaheen Shah Afridi in quick succession before Starc cleaned up.

The Pakistanis padded up after the hosts were all out in their second innings for 262, after resuming on 187-6. Mir Hamza was the best of the bowlers with 4-32, while Afridi took 4-76.

Carey slammed 53 to help Australia build their overnight lead and quieten chatter about his form after losing his place in the one-day side to Josh Inglis.

He resumed on 16 after Australia had bounced back from 16-4 thanks to an attacking 96 from Mitchell Marsh and Smith's gutsy 50.

Rain washes out NZ-B'desh T20

Rain washed out the second Twenty20 international between New Zealand and Bangladesh after only 11 overs Friday, leaving Bangladesh with a 1-0 lead in the three-match series. The match began on time and New Zealand was 72-2 after 11 overs when the heavy rain which had fallen throughout the day in this seaside city returned to Bay Oval. Bangladesh won the toss Friday and sent New Zealand in as it did in the first match of the series, which it won by five wickets for its first ever T20 win over New Zealand in New Zealand. Finn Allen again fell early, dismissed in the second over, but Tim Seifert struck six fours and a six in a quickfire innings of 43 from 23 balls.

SA crush Indian hopes

India's dream of winning a Test series in South Africa for the first time was ended inside three days as they crashed to an innings and 32 runs defeat at SuperSport Park in Centurion on Thursday.

With the series consisting of only two matches they can at best earn a share of the honours if they win the second Test starting in Cape Town on Wednesday.

"We'll regroup and come back," said Indian captain Rohit Sharma after the game. "It's important to regroup as quickly as we can, tough from a loss like these but as sportsmen you go through these times. Got to pick ourselves up."

India had no answer to South Africa's pace attack as they crashed to 131 all out in their second innings, after conceding a 163-run first innings lead.

A day which started with the match evenly poised turned into a rout for the tourists.

Dean Elgar (185) and Marco Jansen (84 not out) transformed a slender 11-run lead for South Africa at the start of play into a strong position.

They shared a 111-run sixth wicket partnership as South Africa took an overnight 256 for five to 408 all out despite the absent of injured captain Temba Bavuma.

Virat Kohli hit an aggressive 76 for India before he was last man out but the rest of the batting collapsed against South Africa's fast bowlers on a lively pitch.

The second innings lasted just 34.1 overs. Kohli hit 12 fours and a six in an 82-ball innings. Shubman Gill made 26 but no other batsman scored more than six.



Dinesh defends NPGA Match Play title

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 29

Dinesh Prajapati defended the title of the Surya Nepal NPGA Match Play, the second event under the Surya Nepal Golf Tour 2023-24, at the Royal Nepal Golf Club on Friday.

Third seeded Dinesh defeated fourth seeded Jayram Shrestha 6&4 in the 36-hole final. With the victory, Dinesh claimed his second career title.

Dinesh finished second behind amateur golfer Sadbhav Acharya in the season opening event, Surya Nepal Central Open at the Gokarna Golf Club last month.

In the final, Jayram took 1-up lead after first nine holes, while the two players were all-square after 18 holes. Dinesh took the lead with a birdie from 30 yards on the 19th hole, while the two players halved next three holes. Dinesh was 2-up after he won the 23rd hole and the pros halved next four holes.

Dinesh extended the lead to 3-up on the 28th hole with a par. After sharing the 29th hole, Dinesh won the next three holes to completed the victory with four holes remaining. Along with the trophy, Dinesh received Rs 60,000, while Jayram earned Rs 42,000.

Earlier, seventh seeded Rame Magar defeated ninth seeded Bhuwan Kumar Rokka 1-up on the final hole to finish third. Rame earned Rs 32,000, while fourth-placed Bhuwan received Rs 24,000. Bhuwan upset Dhana Bahadur Thapa in the first round and he stunned top seeded Bhuvan Nagarkoti in the quarter-finals.

A total of 16 pros took part in the tournament organized by Nepal PGA under the sponsorship of Surya Nepal Pvt Ltd.

AAHA! RARA POKHARA GOLD CUP FROM JAN 23

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec.29

The 23rd edition of Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup, one of the most loved football competition in the country, will kick off on January 23, 2024. The competition will end on February 3.

Issuing a statement on Friday, Sahara Club Pokhara, the main organiser of the competition, said that the competition will consist of departmental clubs, A-Division clubs, Nepal Super League clubs, foreign clubs and the organiser.

Organisers informed that there will be 12 teams in the competition being held in Pokhara Rangasala. The competition has been organised annually since Sahara Club Pokhara's establishment in 2003 making it one of the longest-running tournament in the country.

Last season, Sankata Club of Kathmandu won the competition against Bhutanese Youth Sports Club of USA. The winner was awarded with a purse of Rs. 1.2 million and the runner-up was provided Rs. 600,000.

While the numbers have not been made public yet, organisers informed that the cash prize for the winners will be more this edition than that in the previous one.

The competition's main sponsor is Himshree Foods Pvt. Ltd. The organisers informed that the profit from the competition will be used for the students in Sahara Club Pokhara's academy.

Arsenal fail in Premier League summit bid

AFP
London, Dec. 29



PHOTO: AP
West Ham's Konstantinos Mavropanos, third left, scores his sides second goal during the English Premier League soccer match against Arsenal in England.

Arsenal missed out on the chance to return to the Premier League summit on Thursday, losing 2-0 to West Ham as Tottenham went down in a six-goal thriller at Brighton.

Mikel Arteta's Gunners were top of the tree at Christmas for a second successive year but trail leaders Liverpool by two points at the halfway point of the season.

Last year's runners-up dominated possession at the Emirates but lacked a cutting edge against the disciplined visitors, for whom Tomas Soucek and former Arsenal player Konstantinos Mavropanos scored the goals.

Soucek opened the scoring from close range in the 13th minute following a pass from Jarrod Bowen, with the goal confirmed after a lengthy VAR check looking into whether the ball had gone out of play.

Arsenal surged forward in relentless waves and West Ham goalkeeper Alphonse Areola made a fine reaction save from a Bukayo Saka header on the half-hour.

The England winger hit the post from a tight angle as the clock ticked down towards half-time but Arsenal trailed at the break despite enjoying nearly three-quarters of possession.

The Gunners came out determined to find a response but instead they found themselves 2-0 down when Mavropanos's bullet header cannoned in off the crossbar from James Ward-Prowse's corner.

Gabriel Jesus failed to beat Areola with a header when well-placed and shortly afterwards missed another glorious opportunity with his head at the back post. Arsenal continued to bombard the visitors' goal but could not find a breakthrough and it could have been worse had Said Benrahma managed to convert a late penalty.

Defeat leaves the Gunners in second place on 40 points, one clear of Aston Villa and three ahead of Manchester City, who have a game in hand.

Arteta said his team deserved more for their dominance.

Spurs drama

Tottenham, this season's early pacesetters, remain in fifth spot after losing 4-2 despite threatening an astonishing comeback from 4-0 down against Roberto De Zerbi's Brighton.

Jack Hinshelwood finished with brutal power to put the home side ahead following a weaving run from Joao Pedro along the edge of the penalty area.

Brighton doubled their lead from the penalty spot in the 23rd minute through Pedro, who took full advantage after Dejan Kulusevski was penalised for a pull on Welbeck.

Brazil forward Richarlison twice had the ball in the net after the break but both times he was ruled offside. Pervis Estupinan stretched the lead with a thunderbolt from 30 yards in the 63rd minute and Pedro scored a second penalty 12 minutes later.

Alejo Veliz grabbed what appeared to be a consolation goal in the 81st minute but it galvanised the visitors.

Ben Davies headed home Pedro Porro's deep cross as Spurs threatened to cut through every time they poured forward, with Pierre-Emile Hojbjerg hitting the post during nine frantic minutes of stoppage time.

But Brighton withstood the intense pressure to take all three points.

WEATHER

Saturday

Sunrise at 6:54 am, Sunset at 5:19 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Saturday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly areas of the country , partly cloudy in the terai areas of Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province and Sudur Pashchim Province , and mainly fair in the rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 17 - 19°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Friday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	16.7	5.4	0.0
Dipayal	25.5	9.3	0.0
Dhangadi	18.7	10.2	0.0
Birendranagar	23.7	7.8	0.0
Nepalgunj	16.7	11.0	0.0
Jumla	16.1	-4.8	0.0
Ghorahi	23.3	9.0	0.0
Pokhara	22.2	10.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	16.6	11.0	0.0
Simara	25.0	11.5	0.0
Kathmandu	19.2	7.5	0.0
Okhaldhunga	19.4	8.3	0.0
Taplejung	17.8	5.6	0.0
Dhankuta	24.0	9.8	0.0
Biratnagar	27.2	12.2	0.0
Jomsom	13.0	-5.5	0.0*
Dharan	27.4	15.4	0.0*
Lumle	17.1	6.2	0.0*
Janakpur	29.6	12.8	0.0*
Jiri	16.0	1.6	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

December 30, 2023

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.84	Rs. 133.44
Euro	1	Rs. 146.95	Rs. 147.61
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 169.10	Rs. 169.86
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 158.39	Rs. 159.10
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 90.28	Rs. 90.69
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 100.21	Rs. 100.66
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.67	Rs. 101.12
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.37	Rs. 9.41
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.68	Rs. 18.77
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.42	Rs. 35.58
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.44	Rs. 36.61
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.87	Rs. 3.89
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.17	Rs. 36.33
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.91	Rs. 29.04
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.21	Rs. 10.26
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.25	Rs. 13.31
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.72	Rs. 19.81
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.01	Rs. 17.08
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.28	Rs. 434.23
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.37	Rs. 353.97

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Parsa XI meet Police in final of Pro Club Championship

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 29

Pokhara XI and Nepal Police Club booked their berth for the finals of the Pro Club Championship 2023 after winning against Nepal Army Club and Wonders Club Noida respectively on Friday. The final is being held on Saturday in Birgunj.

In the first semi-final match on Friday, Parsa XI gave a target of 100 to Nepal Army Club in the 20-over game. However, in run chase Army was bowled out at 68 runs in 16.2 overs by Parsa.

Sompal Kami's four wickets, Kushal Malla's three wickets, Shahab Alam's two wickets and Bibek Yadav's one wicket bowled out Parsa for 99 runs in 19.4 overs.

While bowlers did their job, the batting side failed Army.

Sandeep Lamichhane did the most damage to Army's batting with three-wicket haul. He conceded 13 runs in his spell of 3.2 overs.

Anil Sah, Pawan Sarraf and Samsad Mansuri took two wickets each and Ranjit Kumar bagged the remaining one for Parsa.

Lamichhane took the wickets of opener Santosh Karki, Nepal's national cricket team captain Rohit Paudel, and Shahab Alam. Kushal Malla and Paudel, two quality batsmen of the national team, could only score 19 and 8 runs for Army respectively.

On the other semi-final match, Nepal Police Club restricted Wonders Club Noida at 108 in 20 overs to win the match by four runs. Nepal Police had posted a target of 113 for Noida.

Nepal Police reached 112 in the loss of seven wickets with a knock of 34 and 42 runs by Sunil Dhamala and Arjun Saud. Dilip Nath (10 runs in 15 balls) was the only third batsmen for Nepal Police to score in two digits.

Four players scored in two digits for Noida during the chase. However, the team could only score 108 in the loss of nine wickets at the end of 20 overs. Vansh Bedi was the highest scorer for Noida with 43 runs off 40 balls.

Sagar Dhakal took three wickets, Rashid Khan took two and Sher Malla and Lalit Rajbanshi took one wicket each. Karan KC did not take a single wicket as he gave 23 runs in his spell of four overs.

The tournament, which started on December 21, was participated by six teams including four national teams – Nepal Army Club, Nepal Police Club, Armed Police Force Club and Parsa XI – and two foreign teams – Uttar Pradesh Club XI and Wonders Club Noida.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54